How Does State Violence Experienced During Adolescence Shape State–Person Narratives?

Multimodal Causal Evidence from Japanese American Oral Histories

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Abstract

This article asks how state violence experienced during adolescence shapes later-life narratives about the state–person relationship. Using 642 Japanese American oral-history narrators from the Densho Digital Repository, I construct a multimodal outcome framework that distinguishes what kind of relationship to the state is narrated from how that relationship is narrated. On the treatment side, the paper separates developmental timing, cumulative duration, and the severity of confinement, with severity measured through family separation, parental arrest, loyalty conflict, and segregation. Estimation uses double/debiased machine learning under the observed archive sample and two WRA-anchored transport specifications based on inverse-probability and raking weights. The results do not support a simple developmental-window account in which adolescent first exposure by itself dominates later-life outcomes. Broad binary timing is weak, duration is secondary, and the clearest causal signal is aggregate severity. More severe confinement hardens antagonism toward public authority, shifts narrative mass away from wounded belonging, and moves it toward ambivalent estrangement. A component decomposition shows that loyalty conflict carries the most consistent distrust-side signal. The article contributes a causal

framework for subjective state–person injury, a multimodal measurement strategy for oral-history data, and a bounded argument about how non-penal confinement can leave durable narrative legacies.

Introduction

How does state violence experienced during adolescence shape later-life state–person narratives? This paper treats adolescence as the developmental frame that motivates the inquiry, not as a result to be presumed in advance. Exposure during these years can leave enduring traces not only in later political attitudes and behavior but also in the narratives through which people understand their relation to public authority. The empirical task is to ask whether that broader confinement experience leaves different narrative legacies depending on when it begins, how long it lasts, and how severe or betrayal-laden it becomes. Wartime Japanese American incarceration provides an unusually revealing case for examining that process. It joined the coerced confinement of a civilian population to a postwar setting in which the same constitutional order endured and public testimony gradually became possible. The case therefore offers analytic leverage not only on a historically specific injustice but also on a broader class of episodes in which young people are confined through executive authority outside the ordinary criminal process and must later make sense of the same state that acted upon them.

The case differs from the criminological literature on adolescent incarceration in a basic respect. The confinement at issue here was not a penal response to individual conduct but the wartime removal and incarceration of citizens and residents on the basis of ancestry, carried out by the executive branch of the state itself (Commission on Wartime Relocation and Internment of Civilians, 1997; Daniels, 2004). It therefore belongs less to the sociology of punishment than to the analysis of non-penal, administratively organized confinement imposed on civilians, where the forced separation of families, the arrest of

parents, coerced conflicts, and punitive transfer into segregation camps can become central to the injury itself. What matters here is the subjective aftermath of that experience, especially because confinement during the impressionable years may leave a distinctive imprint on political schemas and civic self-understandings (Flanagan, 2013; Krosnick and Alwin, 1989; Pfeifer and Berkman, 2018).

The evidence that state violence leaves lasting marks is extensive. A recent meta-analysis of 172 quantitative studies covering conflicts on every inhabited continent finds robust effects of wartime violence on intergroup hostility and ingroup identification, yet mixed-to-null results for trust, altruism, and civic participation, which collectively span 22 categories but remain confined to observable behavior and survey-elicited attitudes (Barceló, 2025). Broader literatures confirm the pattern: state violence produces durable shifts in political participation, trust, collective action, and partisan alignment (Rozenas et al., 2017; Blattman, 2009; Bellows and Miguel, 2009; Nunn and Wantchekon, 2011; Balcells, 2012; Bauer et al., 2016; Dell and Querubin, 2018; Fontana et al., 2023; Lupu and Peisakhin, 2017), and the political-socialization literature demonstrates that experiences during the impressionable years of youth exert disproportionate influence on lifelong attitudes and beliefs (Krosnick and Alwin, 1989; Sears and Levy, 2003; Giuliano and Spilimbergo, 2014; Alesina and Fuchs-Schündeln, 2007). These findings leave little doubt that state violence has long-term political consequences. Yet even the most comprehensive synthesis reveals a systematic gap: across all 22 outcome categories, the dominant strategy measures legacies of violence through what people do or what they report believing; nowhere does the subjective narrative through which individuals make sense of the state–person relationship appear as an outcome in its own right. What remains open is how incarceration experienced during the formative years reshapes the sense-making through which individuals understand the state–person relationship itself.

Answering this question requires specifying both what the treatment is and what the outcome is. On the treatment side, the paper begins from wider wartime confinement as a

developmental exposure and then analytically unpacks that experience into three linked dimensions, drawing on work in life-course theory and dynamic treatment design (Heckman et al., 2016; Bodory et al., 2022; Giuliano and Spilimbergo, 2014; Flanagan, 2013). Adolescence is not simply a date on a timeline. It is a formative setting within which confinement may vary in when it first interrupts development, how long institutional isolation is sustained, and how intensely the state acts through betrayal, family rupture, and political sorting. The analysis therefore separates three questions that must be compared rather than assumed to rank themselves in advance. Timing asks whether first exposure during the impressionable window of adolescence is encoded differently from comparable exposure experienced in childhood or adulthood. Duration, operationalized as dosage, asks whether prolonged confinement deepens injury through sustained institutional isolation. Aggregate severity asks whether the broader coercive bundle, which includes separation from family, the arrest of parents, coerced conflict over the wartime loyalty questionnaire, and transfer into segregation camps, shapes relational injury above and beyond onset and duration (Nagata et al., 2019). Later sections then return to those same severity elements one by one to ask whether family separation, parental arrest, loyalty conflict, and segregation are in fact interchangeable.

The outcome of interest is the subjective sense-making of the state–person relationship as it surfaces in later-life narratives. This sense-making has two analytically distinct dimensions: what kind of state–person relationship is narrated, and how it is narrated.

The what dimension locates narrators at the two ends of that relationship. One concerns the state itself: authority-stance registers where the narrator has settled along a continuum running from retained trust in a protector that nevertheless failed, through indifference in which the state recedes as a reference point, to adversarial distrust in which the state is narrated as a political enemy (Easton, 1965, 1975; van der Meer, 2017). The other concerns the terms of membership: belonging-stance registers whether the narrator still experiences herself as securely included in the polity or instead as marked by damaged

or oppositional belonging (Goffman, 1963; Link and Phelan, 2001; Somers, 2008; Yuval-Davis, 2006). Together these two stances define the relational settlement at issue: the first asks what kind of authority confined her, the second asks on what terms the polity still recognizes her as a member. Drawing on the distinction between specific and diffuse political support (Easton, 1975), the layered architecture of political trust and distrust (Norris, 2011; Bertsou, 2019; Hooghe, 2011), and developmental accounts of stigma-mediated identity damage (Goffman, 1963; Link and Phelan, 2001; Nagata, 1993), we locate narrators at one of three positions along the diagonal of this two-dimensional space. At one pole, authority-schema injury describes narrators who regard the state as a failed protector: belonging is retained, and the wound remains intelligible precisely because the expectation of protection persists. At the midpoint, shame-mediated identity rupture describes narrators for whom the injury has migrated from institutional critique to selfhood; the state is experienced as a stigmatizing excluder, and civic membership itself is damaged. At the other pole, explicit political distrust describes narrators who cast the state as a political enemy, articulating clear judgments about rights violations and institutional failure within an oppositional stance toward belonging. These three positions are treated as a theoretically ordered set of relational settlements rather than as a mechanical severity ladder.[1]

The what dimension, however, captures only the content of narrative sense-making. Equally important is how that content is delivered. The how dimension draws on the oral-history concept of narrative composure, which refers to the capacity to integrate experience into a tellable, bearable, and coherent story (Summerfield, 2004; Thomson, 1994), to distinguish composed narration (integrated, direct) from discomposed narration (fragmented, hesitant, marked by avoidance or affective rupture). Crossing the three what-axis positions with the two how-axis states yields a 3×2 outcome typology (Table 1). Each cell represents a distinct social fact; the aftermath of state violence lives not only in what

[1]The measurement architecture retains the underlying two-dimensional authority–belonging space, so the analysis does not require treating the three positions as equidistant points on a single latent continuum.

citizens say about the state but in whether they can say it at all. Empirically, however, the article does not force each narrator into a single ideal type. Because each narrator contributes multiple scored segments, the first main outcome is the narrator-level share vector over these six cells rather than a one-cell classification.

Table 1: Six ideal types of later-life state–person narrative outcomes (What × How)

	Composed	**Discomposed**
Authority-schema injury *State as failed protector; retained belonging*	Guarded vigilance Clear articulation of institutional betrayal	Diffuse unease Hesitant, unable to fully name the source of insecurity
Shame-mediated identity rupture *State as stigmatizing excluder; damaged belonging*	Wounded belonging Damaged membership articulated coherently	Stigmatized discomposure Avoidance, fragmentation, shame resistant to narration
Explicit political distrust *State as political enemy; oppositional belonging*	Oppositional citizenship Integrated political critique and rights language	Ambivalent estrangement Political distrust present but contradictory, unresolved

Oral history is valuable here not because it escapes subjectivity but because it preserves forms of sense-making that surveys flatten. Interviews make visible how narrators name authority, where they hesitate, what they avoid, and how injury enters the telling itself (Portelli, 1979, 1991; Abrams, 2016; Lamont and Swidler, 2014; Small, 2009).

The Densho Digital Repository is especially useful because it preserves transcript, audio, and video records of these interviews, along with structured metadata on birth year, interview year, camp assignment, and generation. That multimodal record makes it possible to distinguish what survivors say about the state from how securely or precariously they are able to say it. The what dimension is read primarily from textual content, while the how dimension is constructed from multimodal evidence that combines textual cues with audio prosodic features and video affect markers, so that narrative composure is not collapsed into text alone.

The empirical analysis therefore asks not whether adolescence matters in the abstract,

but whether confinement leaves durable narrative traces and which channel carries them once timing, duration, and aggregate severity are estimated jointly (Chernozhukov et al., 2018; Heckman et al., 2016; Bodory et al., 2022). One set of analyses tracks the narrator-level distribution across six what-by-how positions; another examines movement along the underlying dimensions of authority, belonging, and the multimodal how score. The main results section is therefore organized around six core DML estimates reported in six tables: three main-treatment tables under the unweighted and two transport estimands, followed by three severity-decomposition tables that return to family separation, parental arrest, loyalty conflict, and segregation as distinct channels. This is part of the article's methodological contribution: oral-history materials are used not only to recover a new substantive outcome but also to construct multimodal measures of that outcome in a form that can be analyzed systematically.

Estimation, however, is only as credible as the inferential discipline imposed on it. Causal inference from an oral-history archive requires careful attention to the target population and the selection processes that shape who enters the data. One estimand targets narrators within the Densho archive: those who survived to be interviewed, agreed to participate, and were archived. Two complementary transport specifications then reweight toward the broader wartime-incarcerated population using inverse-probability and raking schemes anchored to War Relocation Authority demographic records (Bodory et al., 2022; Stuart et al., 2011; Dahabreh et al., 2020). All three are treated as primary objects of inference. This design makes it possible to compare the archive itself with two transport views while leaving the central substantive comparison unchanged: the paper asks whether the most stable signal belongs to developmental timing, cumulative duration, or aggregate severity, rather than assuming at the outset that the broad adolescent contrast must dominate.

Three selection concerns merit explicit discussion. First, archive-entry selection: the narrators in the corpus are those who survived, consented, and were recorded. This is not

unique to oral history, since survey data face analogous survival, nonresponse, and panel attrition, but the selection is more visible here (Portelli, 1991; Small, 2009). The analysis addresses this through a WRA-anchored reweighting scheme. Second, outcome-layer selection on the how dimension: narrators whose injury remains most deeply discomposed may be least likely to narrate at all, introducing a potential composure–participation correlation. This possibility is examined in two steps: the main text reports a direct complete-case handling check, and the appendix extends the analysis with fuller checks on who enters the archive, whether the same how-side pattern appears where it should not, and how sensitive the findings are to stronger assumptions about unseen cases. These latter analyses help bound the scope of the how findings, but they do not eliminate narratability-based selection. Third, intersubjectivity: unlike purely qualitative research, where the interviewer co-constructs meaning and shapes the agenda in real time (Frisch, 1990; Portelli, 1991), the measurement strategy used here draws text, audio, and video evidence from archived recordings, thereby holding the interview interaction constant across cases but also bracketing the interviewer's *in situ* interpretive role (Abrams, 2016; Passerini, 2003). This is treated as a scope condition rather than as an eliminable bias.

Any causal finding is bounded by the case from which it is drawn. Establishing the scope of generalizability requires specifying the population, context, and treatment conditions under which estimated effects are expected to hold (Findley et al., 2021). To bound the scope of our findings, we position the Japanese American incarceration within a comparative typology defined by two axes: (1) the degree of legacy inheritance from the perpetrating state, meaning the extent to which the post-violence state retains institutional, legal, and symbolic continuity with the coercive regime (Olick and Robbins, 1999; Zubrzycki and Woźny, 2020); and (2) the degree of expressive openness, that is, whether the post-violence environment permits victims to publicly reflect on, contest, and narrate their experience (Rothschild, 2025; Sutton, 2015). The Japanese American case is distinctive because it combines high legacy inheritance, as the perpetrating state persisted with

no regime rupture and the constitutional order that authorized incarceration continued, alongside high expressive openness, achieved through decades of community organizing.

Our findings are most directly generalizable to cases that share both conditions: cases in which the perpetrating state's institutional legacy persists and in which the post-violence environment eventually permits reflection. They should not be assumed to transport straightforwardly to settings characterized by regime rupture (where the state–person relational continuity is broken) or by persistent expressive closure (where the observable narrative range is truncated).

Within these scope conditions, the article makes three contributions. At the theoretical level, it extends the state-violence literature beyond behavioral and attitudinal outcomes by defining and measuring subjective state–person injury as a causal target. The claim is not that participation and trust are unimportant but that they are incomplete: state violence also restructures the narrative grammar through which individuals understand their relationship to the authority that confined them. In terms of measurement, the 3×2 What $\times$ How framework provides a structured typology that joins narrative content to narrative delivery, an intersection that oral-history theory has long insisted on (Portelli, 1979; Summerfield, 2004) but that has rarely been rendered in a form suitable for systematic analysis. Methodologically, the article shows how archival oral-history materials can be used to construct multimodal measures of narrative injury. By combining text with audio and video, it becomes possible to distinguish what survivors say about the state from how securely or precariously they are able to say it. The methodological contribution lies less in importing a technique for its own sake than in making a difficult sociological outcome observable in a form that can be analyzed systematically.

The remainder of the article proceeds as follows. Section 1 provides a concise account of wartime Japanese American incarceration and the postwar trajectory of reflection and redress. Section 2 reviews the literature on the subjective consequences of state violence, develops authority-stance and belonging-stance as the two endpoints of the

narrated state–person relationship, introduces the how dimension of narrative composure, and elaborates the substantive content of each cell in the 3×2 outcome typology. Section 3 provides the literature-to-estimation bridge linking wartime confinement as a developmental problem to the outcome typology, then disaggregates that broader claim into H1 on timing, H2 on dosage, H3 on aggregate severity, and H4 on severity-component differentiation. Section 4 describes the Densho data source, its strengths and limitations. Section 5 presents the measurement and operationalization strategy for the three treatment channels and the two parallel outcome tracks. Section 6 specifies the causal-inference model, assumptions, and estimation. Section 7 reports the main treatment results, supplementary interaction estimates, and severity-decomposition results, and adjudicates H1 through H4 within the results discussion. Section 8 reports the treatment-operationalization, restricted-severity-bundle, and complete-case missing-data checks. Section 9 concludes with discussion, implications, and scope limitations.

1 Wartime Incarceration and Postwar Reflection

The wartime incarceration of Japanese Americans constitutes one of the most extensive exercises of executive coercion against a civilian population in twentieth-century U.S. history. Between 1942 and 1946, approximately 120,000 persons of Japanese ancestry, roughly two-thirds of whom were native-born citizens, were removed from West Coast communities and confined in government-run camps on the sole basis of racial ancestry (Commission on Wartime Relocation and Internment of Civilians, 1997; Daniels, 2004). Unlike criminal incarceration, the confinement was neither preceded by individual adjudication nor justified by evidence of disloyalty; it was authorized by Executive Order 9066 as a collective wartime-security measure and subsequently upheld by the Supreme Court in Korematsu v. United States (1944), a decision not formally repudiated until 2018 (Robinson, 2001). The episode is therefore not merely a historical injustice but a constitutionally

authorized act of state violence[2] directed at the state's own citizens, executed within and sustained by the ordinary legal apparatus of a functioning democracy.

The incarceration proceeded in two phases. In the spring and summer of 1942, the Army's Wartime Civil Control Administration transferred Japanese American families to temporary assembly centers, typically converted racetracks and fairgrounds, before relocating them to ten permanent War Relocation Authority (WRA) camps in remote interior regions (Daniels, 2004; Robinson, 2001). Peak population was reached by November 1942, when more than 110,000 individuals were held across the ten WRA sites (Commission on Wartime Relocation and Internment of Civilians, 1997). Within the camps, the federal government administered education, work, health, and civic life for the confined population. Adolescents experienced the full institutional apparatus: mandatory school attendance delivered by a mix of recruited non-Japanese teachers and confined community members, participation in camp labor and recreational programs, and exposure to the loyalty questionnaire of 1943, which forced individuals as young as seventeen to declare unqualified allegiance to a government that had incarcerated them (Ikeda, 2014; Lyon, 2024). Those who refused or equivocated were segregated at Tule Lake, compounding the coercive exposure with within-camp punishment and family separation (Daniels, 2004).

The postwar decades were initially characterized by widespread community silence about the incarceration experience, often attributed to the cultural norm of *gaman*, or enduring with patience, and to the pragmatic desire to reintegrate into a society that had excluded them (Nagata, 1993). The political environment shifted beginning in the late 1960s and 1970s, as the Sansei (third generation) began publicly raising questions about the wartime experience, a process reinforced by the broader civil-rights climate (Maki et al., 1999). The Commission on Wartime Relocation and Internment of Civilians (1981–1983) gathered public testimony from more than 750 witnesses, producing the first offi-

[2]Here state refers to the enduring constitutional order rather than a particular administration. Wartime incarceration is treated as a coercive modality of state violence: injurious confinement carried out through the legal and institutional apparatus of that order.

cial acknowledgment that incarceration was driven by "race prejudice, war hysteria, and a failure of political leadership" (Commission on Wartime Relocation and Internment of Civilians, 1997). The Civil Liberties Act of 1988 provided formal governmental apology and individual redress payments (Maki et al., 1999).

Within this environment of institutional validation and growing public testimony, the Densho Digital Repository was founded in the late 1990s, recording video oral-history interviews with Japanese Americans who experienced wartime incarceration. The archive, which also serves as the primary empirical source for this study, is itself an artifact of the expressive openness that the postwar trajectory produced: by the time most interviews were conducted (late 1990s through 2010s), narrators operated within an environment in which public testimony about incarceration was institutionally supported, legally validated, and culturally recognized.

The expressive environment just described is one of the two conditions that make the Japanese American case especially revealing. The second is high legacy inheritance: there was no regime change. Executive Order 9066 was issued, the camps were operated, and the exclusion orders were rescinded only incrementally beginning in 1945 by the same constitutional government that preceded and succeeded the war (Robinson, 2001). The Supreme Court affirmed the government's authority while incarceration was under way, and although the United States later established a federal commission of inquiry and enacted formal redress legislation, the constitutional and institutional order that authorized coercion continued unbroken (de Brito et al., 2001; Olick and Robbins, 1999; Zubrzycki and Woźny, 2020). What matters here is not regime transition alone but whether the same constitutional authority remained the institutional horizon within which survivors later narrated the episode. Narrators who speak decades later therefore address not a democratized successor but the enduring constitutional order that confined them.

High legacy inheritance combined with high expressive openness allows both ends of the state–person relationship to remain visible: the perpetrating state's institutional con-

tinuity preserves the relational structure, while the open expressive environment permits narrators to articulate the full range of responses, from restrained to oppositional, and from composed to discomposed, without legal or political sanction.

Three comparator cases clarify what this combination makes visible. China's Great Leap Famine (1959–1961) represents high legacy inheritance with low expressive openness. The party-state that produced the famine remains the governing authority: there has been no regime transition, no independent truth commission, and no formal acknowledgment of the scale of famine mortality (Dikötter, 2010; Thaxton, 2008). State censorship, patriotic education campaigns, and selective rehabilitations have produced what Rothschild (2025) terms "selective expression": survivors can narrate certain dimensions of their experience, particularly those that align with official frames of collective hardship, while accounts that implicate party leadership or the structural logic of collectivization remain suppressed. The Chinese case thus shares the Japanese American case's high legacy inheritance but lacks the expressive openness that would permit the full range of narrative responses to be observed.

Post-genocide Rwanda (1994–present) occupies an intermediate position: medium legacy inheritance and low-to-medium expressive openness. The Rwandan Patriotic Front (RPF) government that ended the genocide was not the perpetrating regime, representing a partial regime transition. However, the post-genocide state has exercised extensive control over how the violence is publicly narrated. Genocide-ideology laws criminalize speech deemed divisionist, the gacaca community courts combined local testimony with state-supervised adjudication, and the official memory regime privileges a unified national narrative that subordinates Hutu civilian suffering to Tutsi victimhood (Longman, 2017; Thomson, 2013; Berry, 2018). Survivors and perpetrators alike operate within a tightly managed expressive environment in which certain narrative positions, particularly those implicating RPF reprisals or questioning the official periodization of violence, carry legal and social risk (Jessee, 2017). Rwanda thus illustrates how the absence of full

expressive openness truncates the observable narrative range even when the perpetrating regime itself has been displaced.

Argentina and Chile after their respective military dictatorships (1976–1983 and 1973–1990) represent low legacy inheritance with high expressive openness. In both cases, authoritarian rule ended through negotiated or electoral transitions that produced new democratic governments, truth commissions (CONADEP in Argentina, the Rettig Commission in Chile), and, in Argentina's case, criminal prosecution of former junta leaders (Robben, 2005; de Brito et al., 2001). The institutional, legal, and symbolic apparatus of the coercive regime was substantially dismantled: the perpetrating regime ceased to exist as the governing authority, and the successor democracies actively constructed a human-rights framework within which victims were invited to testify. The combination of regime rupture and robust transitional justice created a highly open expressive environment, but the state–person relational structure that our framework analyzes, in which the same state remains the operative institutional order after the coercive episode, is absent.

Among the four cases, the Japanese American case alone combines high legacy inheritance with high expressive openness. The first preserves relational continuity between the perpetrating state and the confined individual; the second permits the full range of narrative responses to surface. Together they make it possible to observe the long-run narrative consequences of incarceration, including whether experiences first lived in adolescence take different narrative forms depending on when confinement begins, how long it lasts, and how sharply it is organized through family rupture and political sorting, without the truncation imposed by censorship or the relational discontinuity introduced by regime change. Table 2 summarizes the four cases along these two axes.

Table 2: Post-violence political environments and expected narrative consequences

	Legacy	**Openness**	**Expected narrative pattern**
China (Great Leap Famine)	High	Low	Selective expression; narrative content compressed toward injury or rupture; discomposed delivery likely (Rothschild, 2025)
Rwanda (post-genocide)	Medium	Low–Med	State-managed narrative; narrative content constrained by the official memory regime (Jessee, 2017)
Argentina / Chile (post-dictatorship)	Low	High	Rights-centered distrust narratives more readily articulated in composed form after regime rupture (Sutton, 2015)
Japanese American incarceration (this study)	**High**	**High**	**Full narrative range observable; both composed and discomposed forms publicly expressible** (Maki et al., 1999)

2 Subjective Consequences of State Violence

The literature on the long-run consequences of state violence, and of related forms of political violence more broadly, is rich on behavior and attitudes but thinner on the forms of self-understanding through which injury is interpreted and carried forward. A recent meta-analysis of 172 studies spanning every inhabited continent sorts these legacies into 22 outcome categories across violence attitudes, intergroup orientations, prosociality, and political participation (Barceló, 2025). That synthesis is valuable precisely because it shows how much cumulative knowledge now exists about downstream political and social effects. Yet even a comprehensive inventory of attitudes and behaviors leaves open a prior question: what kind of relationship to the injuring state survivors believe themselves to inhabit.

That gap is not simply empirical; it is conceptual. Survey research can measure already stabilized orientations, but it is far less capable of recovering the structure of sense-making through which those orientations are produced and narrated (Lamont and Swidler, 2014; Small, 2009). State violence is not only an external shock that changes later preferences. It is also a rupture within a relationship between persons and political authority. A relational perspective therefore directs attention away from isolated attitudes and toward the patterned ways actors narrate authority, obligation, injury, and membership (Emirbayer, 1997). Trauma theory points in a similar direction: injury can shatter ordinarily taken-for-granted assumptions about protection, fairness, and social intelligibility (Janoff-Bulman, 1992). The question, then, is not only whether state violence produces more or less trust, participation, or civic attachment; it is how survivors later make sense of the state that confined them and of their own place within the polity that authorized the confinement.

This sense-making has two dimensions. The what dimension concerns the substantive content of the narrator's understanding of the state–person relationship: what kind of authority the state is, and on what terms the narrator understands herself to stand in

relation to the polity it defines. The how dimension concerns the narrative form in which that understanding is expressed: has the injury been integrated into a tellable, coherent account, or does it remain fragmented and discomposed?

2.1 The What Dimension: Making Sense of the State–Person Relationship

The what dimension identifies the substantive categories through which narrators make sense of the two constitutive ends of the state–person relationship. One end is the state itself: the narrator must arrive at some understanding of what kind of authority confined her, whether a protector that failed, a power indifferent to her fate, or an adversary against whom standing must be claimed. The other end is not identity in the abstract but the narrator's understanding of the terms on which the polity recognizes, conditions, or withholds membership for someone like her: whether that state-defined relationship survived the confinement, was damaged by it, or was repudiated in response to it. The first is authority-stance; the second is belonging-stance (Easton, 1965, 1975; Marshall, 1950; Somers, 1994, 2008; Yuval-Davis, 2006). These are not two independent scales to be measured separately and then combined; they are the two endpoints of a single relational settlement, and their joint configuration defines the substantive shape of later-life injury.

Authority-stance. Authority-stance asks what kind of authority the narrator understands the state to be. The foundational discriminant is the difference between dissatisfaction with particular officials and policy outputs, on the one hand, and injury to the legitimacy of the political order itself, on the other (Easton, 1965, 1975; van der Meer, 2017). Disappointment with incumbents need not unsettle the belief that public authority is, in principle, rightful and protective; under state violence, however, the injury can reach precisely that deeper level. What matters is not only whether authorities acted badly, but whether the state can still appear as a credible guarantor of protection at all.

Three further distinctions sharpen this axis. First, criticism of regime performance and criticism of regime principles are related but separable (Norris, 2011). For Japanese American narrators, this matters because the constitutional order that authorized incarceration persisted after the camps closed: some narrators can therefore describe incarceration as a betrayal within democracy, an egregious failure that leaves intact a residual expectation of protection. Second, distrust is not merely low trust; it can be an active, organized orientation of suspicion toward institutions and their claims (Bertsou, 2019). At one extreme, the state is no longer an authority that failed but an adversary whose promise of protection was always conditional. Third, compliance and consent are contingent and unevenly distributed across social groups (Levi, 1997; Tyler, 2006). Even narrators who retain a normative expectation of protection may describe that expectation as permanently conditioned by the betrayal.

These distinctions define a continuum along which authority-stance moves from retained trust in the state as a protector that nevertheless failed, through indifference in which the state is no longer the central reference point for the narrator's self-understanding, to explicit adversarial distrust in which the state is narrated as a political enemy.

Belonging-stance. Belonging-stance asks on what terms the narrator understands herself to belong to the polity as a state-defined member. Citizenship is not only a legal status but full membership in a social and political community, that is, a lived relation to a social contract of protection, obligation, and recognition (Marshall, 1950), and that membership is narratively constituted and politically contested rather than simply possessed (Somers, 1994, 2008; Yuval-Davis, 2006). The relevant question is therefore not whether one formally has rights but whether one can inhabit a story in which those rights, protections, and obligations still seem to apply to someone like oneself.

When confinement is organized through racialized suspicion, damaged belonging often takes the form of stigma and shame. Public discrediting can migrate inward and

reorganize self-understanding (Goffman, 1963); stigma operates as a social process of labeling, stereotyping, separation, and status loss (Link and Phelan, 2001). For Japanese Americans, the injury was especially potent because the mark that justified confinement was ancestry rather than conduct, a racialized identity experienced as ineradicable (Nagata, 1993). Read through the lens of shattered assumptions, this is not merely a loss of confidence in institutions but a destabilization of one's place in the moral order of membership (Janoff-Bulman, 1992).

As with authority-stance, belonging-stance admits of degrees. At one end the narrator retains full identification with the polity; civic membership survives the injury. At the other the narrator has moved to an explicitly oppositional position, claiming standing against the polity that excluded her through contentious acts of citizenship rather than through identification with it (Isin and Nielsen, 2015; Somers, 2008). Between these poles lies a middle region of partial or absent belonging, where civic selfhood is damaged even though it is neither securely retained nor politically repurposed.

Three diagonal positions in the authority–belonging space. Authority-stance and belonging-stance could, in principle, be crossed as a full two-dimensional matrix, and off-diagonal combinations may appear as fleeting or mixed narrative moments. But the object of analysis is not a battery of independent institutional attitudes and identity claims; it is the narrator's settlement of a state–person relationship. The dominant positions therefore lie along the diagonal of this joint space. This covariance is substantive, not accidental: the way a narrator understands the authority that confined her constrains the way she can understand her own membership, and vice versa. Three configurations in which authority-stance and belonging-stance co-vary in empirically recurrent and theoretically interpretable ways appear below (Table 1).

Authority-schema injury (state as failed protector; belonging retained). Authority-stance registers the state as a protector that was normatively trusted and therefore capable

of betrayal; belonging-stance remains intact. The narrator still operates within a frame in which authority should have protected; the betrayal is intelligible precisely because the protection expectation persists (Easton, 1975; Levi, 1997).

Shame-mediated identity rupture (state as stigmatizing excluder; damaged belonging). Authority-stance registers indifference: the state is no longer the central reference point for the narrator's self-understanding. Belonging-stance registers damaged belonging rather than oppositional belonging. The injury has migrated from the level of political authority to the level of identity and selfhood (Goffman, 1963; Link and Phelan, 2001; Nagata, 1993).

Explicit political distrust (state as political enemy; oppositional belonging). Authority-stance registers the state as an adversary whose claims are met with active suspicion; belonging-stance registers opposition in the form of contentious claim-making rather than withdrawal against the polity (Bertsou, 2019; Isin and Nielsen, 2015). Critique itself becomes a mode of membership; in Hirschman's terms, voice rather than exit (Hirschman, 1970).

The three positions do not map onto the paper's treatment-side severity measure, introduced later, nor do they form a single ladder of more or less injury. A narrator in the injury category may be extremely angry but still locate the state within a protection frame. A narrator in the rupture category may appear less politically articulate but carry a deeper wound to membership and selfhood. A narrator in the distrust category may be highly composed and politically engaged but has fundamentally repositioned the state as an adversary. The ordering from injury through rupture to distrust is therefore treated as a theoretically motivated ordering of relational settlements rather than as a mechanical severity ladder. The measurement architecture retains the underlying two-dimensional space, so the empirical analysis does not require treating the three positions as equidistant points on a single latent continuum (Hooghe, 2011; Emirbayer, 1997).

Rupture, however, covers a broad region of the authority–belonging space. Some nar-

rators describe a more adaptive rupture, in which community bonds are partly rebuilt; others describe a deeper rupture, marked by lasting damage to selfhood, hiding identity, or feeling like an outsider in both Japanese and American communities (Nagata, 1993; Link and Phelan, 2001). Because that distinction is difficult to operationalize reliably from archival summaries alone, the analysis retains a three-class what-axis while treating the internal variation within rupture as a substantive refinement.

2.2 The How Dimension: Narrative Composure and Tellability

The what dimension specifies the substantive content of the narrator's settlement of the state–person relationship. The how dimension specifies something analytically independent: the narrative form in which that content is delivered. Oral historians have long argued that retrospective narration is composed at the intersection of lived experience and publicly available narrative forms (Popular Memory Group, 1982; Thomson, 1994; Dawson, 1994). Composure, in this tradition, names the partial achievement by which a narrator renders a difficult past both bearable and socially intelligible (Summerfield, 2004; Dawson, 2026). It is not equivalent to factual accuracy, emotional tranquility, or clinical recovery. A narrator may be historically precise and still narratively discomposed; another may speak fluently about one domain of the past and fragment around another.

Oral-history work accordingly treats hesitation, contradiction, self-correction, silence, and affective flooding as consequential rather than as mere noise (Portelli, 1979, 1991; Hollway and Jefferson, 2000). Such moments mark points at which experience has not been fully integrated into narrative form, or at which available public vocabularies fail to contain the injury being described. Recent work on Northern Ireland life stories makes the same point from a different archive: the afterlives of conflict are carried not only in stated opinions but in the uneven narrative labor through which people position themselves in relation to violence, responsibility, and belonging (Dawson, 2026). Composure therefore remains distinct from substantive stance. The same authority injury or belonging rupture

can be narrated as a settled interpretation or as an unfinished wound.

This has an immediate implication for what an oral-history archive can observe. If composure names the achieved capacity to render difficult experience into a tellable account, then narrators whose injury remains most fragmented or discomposed may also be least likely to narrate at all, to sustain long-form testimony, or to leave archive-ready transcripts. The how dimension is therefore not only a substantive dimension of outcome; it is also more exposed than the what dimension to selection on narratability. Later sections return to this point as a scope condition on inference rather than as a reason to collapse how into what.

2.3 The Six-Cell Typology of Later-Life Narrative Outcomes

Crossing the three what-axis positions with the two how-axis states yields the 3×2 outcome typology presented in Table 1. The six cells are not developmental stages, and individual narrators may move among them across the life course or within a single interview. They are analytic distinctions that clarify what kind of injury is being described and whether that injury has been narratively integrated.

Guarded vigilance joins authority-schema injury to composed narration. The narrator treats the state as a failed protector and can identify the institutional decisions, actors, or legal rationales through which the betrayal occurred. Yet the criticism remains lodged within a broader framework of retained legitimacy: the constitutional order is wounded but not wholly abandoned, and cooperation persists as something conditional rather than presumed (Easton, 1975; Levi, 1997).

Diffuse unease also centers authority-schema injury but in discomposed form. The narrator senses that something in the relation to authority was broken without fully stabilizing that perception into an explicit account. The result is hesitation, indirection, or abrupt topic shifts when the state enters the story. Unlike stigmatized discomposure, the object of narrative difficulty here is the state as authority rather than the self as a stigmatized

member; the narrator struggles to articulate what the government did or why, not what she became as a result (Hollway and Jefferson, 2000).

Wounded belonging names the composed version of shame-mediated identity rupture. The narrator can describe with clarity how incarceration marked him or her as socially suspect, how public exclusion migrated into self-understanding, and how civic membership came to feel injured rather than secure. Stigma is recognized not as a private failing but as a structured social process that reorganized the terms of belonging (Goffman, 1963; Link and Phelan, 2001).

Stigmatized discomposure carries the same substantive injury in a less narratively settled form. Shame, inadequacy, or exclusion appear through broken syntax, minimization, contradiction, or prolonged silence rather than through sustained analysis. The injury remains difficult to convert into a coherent civic story; this is the terrain on which intergenerational silence becomes sociologically visible (Nagata, 1993; Summerfield, 2004).

Oppositional citizenship joins explicit political distrust to composed narration. The narrator speaks in the language of rights, critique, and institutional judgment with enough distance to sustain a coherent oppositional position. Belonging is not relinquished but reworked into a claim against the polity that denied equal standing, so that critique itself becomes a mode of political membership (Isin and Nielsen, 2015; Somers, 2008; Yuval-Davis, 2006; Hirschman, 1970).

Ambivalent estrangement combines explicit political distrust with discomposure. The narrator condemns institutions and may clearly reject official accounts, yet cannot sustain a fully integrated oppositional narrative. Critique coexists with residual attachment, self-doubt, or unassimilated grief, making visible that distrust and belonging can remain entangled rather than cleanly opposed (Thomson, 1994; Hollway and Jefferson, 2000).

The typology separates the object of narration from the degree of narrative settlement. It makes it possible to ask whether exposure to state violence experienced during adolescence reorganizes the substantive meaning of the state–person relationship, the compo-

sure with which that relationship is narrated, or both, and whether any such difference is carried by when confinement begins, how long it lasts, or how coercively it is organized. The framework is offered as a measurement architecture rather than as a closed set of deductive hypotheses.

3 Treatment Configurations and Research Hypotheses

Existing research already shows that state violence leaves durable downstream legacies, but it has mainly measured those legacies through attitudes, trust, participation, and behavior rather than through the later-life narrative sense-making by which survivors understand their relation to the state (Lupu and Peisakhin, 2017; Rozenas et al., 2017; Nunn and Wantchekon, 2011; Barceló, 2025). That gap cannot be addressed by treating wartime confinement as a single undifferentiated exposure. The same broader developmental experience may leave different later-life narrative traces depending on when confinement first interrupts development, how long institutional isolation lasts, and how sharply coercion is organized through betrayal, family rupture, and political sorting. The treatment must therefore be decomposed into timing, dosage, and aggregate severity. Timing asks whether developmental onset matters as such. Dosage asks whether prolonged confinement acts through institutionalized chronicity. Aggregate severity asks whether the degree to which confinement was organized through sharper coercive forms carries an independent later-life effect net of timing and dosage. These are not competing labels for the same experience but distinct causal channels nested inside the broader confinement experience.

What follows is therefore not a loose list of descriptive expectations but a sequence of causal claims about what, within the broader confinement experience, is likely to leave the deepest later-life narrative trace. The first claim asks whether developmental timing matters in its own right. The second asks whether duration acts through institutionalized

chronicity. The third asks whether the aggregate-severity channel carries an independent causal effect. The fourth asks whether the elements that compose that aggregate severity measure are substantively distinct rather than interchangeable. These four claims organize the paper's main theoretical bridge.

H1: Timing. The literature on impressionable years and political development argues that experiences during adolescence can leave especially durable traces in later orientations and self-understandings (Krosnick and Alwin, 1989; Sears and Levy, 2003; Flanagan, 2013; Pfeifer and Berkman, 2018). Work on formative shocks reaches a similar conclusion in adjacent settings by showing that macro-political or economic disruptions experienced during the formative window can reshape adult preferences and orientations (Giuliano and Spilimbergo, 2014; Alesina and Fuchs-Schündeln, 2007). In the present setting, that logic motivates a timing hypothesis inside the broader history of wartime confinement. If developmental timing is an independent mechanism, then first exposure during adolescence should have a distinct causal effect on later-life state–person narration relative to comparable exposure outside adolescence, even after dosage and aggregate severity are jointly adjusted. The central expectation is not that adolescence must mechanically dominate all later results, but that a first encounter with confinement during the impressionable years may leave a distinctive mark on where survivors later settle in relation to authority and belonging. That expectation is strongest on the what dimension, though a timing effect on narrative delivery remains possible.

H2: Dosage. Dosage rests on a different mechanism family. The relevant literature is cumulative inequality and life-course chronicity, where sustained adversity accumulates into durable divergence rather than operating only through a single onset event (Schafer et al., 2011; Ben-Shlomo and Kuh, 2002; Ferraro and Shippee, 2009). Applied to coercive state confinement, this literature reframes prolonged incarceration as institutionalized chronicity: removal from ordinary family, school, work, and civic life is sustained over

time, and that duration may itself carry a long-run causal effect on later state–person sense-making. H2 therefore asks whether confinement duration matters net of developmental onset and qualitative coercive form. The directional expectation is that longer confinement should act primarily on the what dimension by moving narrators toward more antagonistic authority-stance and more distrust-side positions, though a duration effect on the how dimension remains empirically possible. The claim is thus that prolonged institutional isolation may carry its own imprint once developmental onset and coercive form are held apart from it. The joint causal tables are therefore asked not whether duration matters at all, but whether it remains an independent channel once timing and aggregate severity are estimated alongside it.

H3: Aggregate severity. H3 treats aggregate severity not as generic intensity but as the degree to which confinement was organized through sharper coercive forms. Trauma theory argues that severe injury can reorganize the basic assumptions through which actors interpret protection, fairness, and intelligibility (Janoff-Bulman, 1992). Research on Japanese American incarceration places that claim in a racialized and intergenerational setting, showing that wartime confinement was experienced not merely as stress but as relational injury (Nagata, 1993; Nagata et al., 2019). The institutional-betrayal and complex-trauma literatures sharpen the same point by showing that harm inflicted by a supposedly protective institution can carry a different downstream meaning from harm inflicted by an external aggressor (Smith and Freyd, 2013; Cloitre et al., 2019). H3 therefore predicts that higher aggregate severity should have a distinct causal effect on later state–person narration by moving narrators away from rupture-side positions and toward more explicit distrust-side outcomes, while also hardening antagonistic authority-stance. This hypothesis is expected to operate most clearly on the what dimension, though any effect on narrative composure remains secondary.

H4: Severity-Component Differentiation. Once severity is understood as qualitative coercive form, it cannot remain a black-box index. Family separation, parental arrest, loyalty conflict over the wartime questionnaire[3], and transfer to segregation camps encode distinct forms of injury. Family separation most directly captures attachment disruption and household rupture (Nagata, 1993). Parental arrest captures a shock to household authority produced by direct state intrusion into family order. Loyalty conflict most directly captures accusation, coerced political sorting, and betrayal-like injury in the sense developed by the institutional-betrayal literature (Smith and Freyd, 2013; Cloitre et al., 2019). Segregation captures escalated exclusion and institutional ostracism on top of baseline confinement. H4 therefore predicts non-equivalent causal effects across the four severity components rather than equal effects across all of them. The strongest directional expectation is that the component most directly tied to accusation and coerced sorting should be the one most clearly linked to distrust-side movement on the what dimension. The point is not that every component must matter equally, but that the more explicitly political forms of accusation and sorting should be least interchangeable with the rest. Empirically, this question requires returning to family separation, parental arrest, loyalty conflict, and segregation as distinct channels rather than leaving them collapsed inside a single severity summary.

4 The Densho Digital Repository and the Study Population

The empirical material for this article comes from the Densho Digital Repository (DDR), a public oral-history archive devoted to the wartime incarceration of Japanese Ameri-

[3]The 1943 WRA loyalty questionnaire, especially Questions 27 and 28, asked incarcerated Japanese Americans to declare willingness to serve in the U.S. military and to forswear allegiance to the Japanese emperor. Because the questionnaire was administered under confinement and used to sort individuals and families into loyal and disloyal categories, it generated accusations of disloyalty, intra-family conflict, and transfer pressures toward segregation settings such as Tule Lake (Daniels, 2004; Ikeda, 2014; Lyon, 2024).

cans (Ikeda, 2014; Densho, 2026a). As Section 1 showed, the archive is itself a product of the postwar movement from silence toward public testimony. That provenance matters analytically. DDR is not simply a storage site for interviews; it is a historically produced setting in which survivors later rendered incarceration narratable, interpretable, and publicly legible.

DDR interviews are video-recorded life histories that move through prewar life, removal, camp experience, postwar resettlement, and later reflection. Because each interview is divided into topical segments, the archive preserves the testimony both as a whole life story and as a sequence of smaller narrative scenes, each with aligned transcript, audio, and video records. Narrator-level metadata provide the biographical anchors for the analysis: birth year, generational cohort (Issei, Nisei, Kibei, Sansei), gender, prewar residence, camp assignment, and interview date. The full archive used here contains 1,011 narrators, 1,191 interviews, and more than 20,000 transcript segments. Interviews span 1983 to 2024, with the center of gravity in the late 1990s through the mid-2010s.[4]

The analytic sample is not all narrators in DDR. It is the subset for whom incarceration belongs to personal biography rather than inherited family memory. That restriction matters because DDR also contains partner collections whose connection to wartime confinement is more heterogeneous. The first stage of sample construction therefore removes postwar-born descendants, narrators whose relation to incarceration is indirect rather than personal, and cases in which the surviving biographical record is too thin to establish first-hand confinement. These exclusions leave 805 narrators with plausible personal exposure to wartime incarceration.

The analysis then narrows further to narrators whose treatment history can actually be placed in time. In practice, that requires enough information on birth year, facility assignment, and historical facility windows to recover age at first exposure and cumu-

[4]That span does not imply a single uniform interview context. The design instead treats interview year and age at interview as part of the narrative-production context and uses auxiliary checks to probe whether the how-side findings are being driven by interviewer or recording-period artifacts rather than by later-life narrative settlement itself.

lative confinement. Applying that requirement yields the treatment-observed sample of 688 narrators used in the main analyses.

Three features of that population matter for the argument. First, it is overwhelmingly Nisei and heavily concentrated in West Coast families, mirroring the social geography of wartime removal. Second, exposure is internally heterogeneous: adolescence is the modal timing category, but childhood and adult first exposure are also common, and betrayal severity is distributed across more than one profile. Third, the archive captures retrospective testimony rather than immediate reaction. This is a substantive advantage for the present question, because the article asks how narrators later organize their views of the state–person relationship rather than how they reacted in the moment. At the same time, it is also a source of scope and selection concern. Interviews were conducted, on average, more than six decades after first exposure, so the observed outcomes register a later-life settlement with incarceration shaped by postwar family life, community memory, the politics of redress, and the selection processes through which public testimony became possible. Missingness on the directly observed archive covariates remains low, and Table 3 reports the final merged distribution of the recovered pre-treatment baseline block that enters the adjustment set. For the narrative outcomes, the same table summarizes the three continuous outcome dimensions among narrators with the final scored outcome battery and the narrator-level distribution across the six narrator-facing outcome positions. The six-category compositional outcome still enters the main causal analysis directly rather than through a dominant-type tabulation.

The Densho archive is selective by construction. Narrators had to survive to the date of interview, agree to testify, and be drawn into the community and institutional networks through which public narration became possible. That selectivity is not incidental to the case; it is part of the same postwar process that made the archive possible. At the same time, it means the archive cannot be treated as a probability sample of all those who were confined (Portelli, 1991; Small, 2009).

Table 3: Descriptive Profile of the Study Population ($N = 688$)

Panel A. Social Composition

Characteristic	Category	N	%
Generation	Nisei	580	84.3
	Sansei	81	11.8
	Kibei	13	1.9
	Issei	9	1.3
	Missing	5	0.7
Gender	Male	361	52.5
	Female	323	46.9
	Missing	4	0.6
Region	West Coast	620	90.1
	Inland	51	7.4
	Hawaii	14	2.0
	Missing	3	0.4

Panel B. Exposure Profile

Dimension	Category	N	%
Timing	Childhood	149	21.7
	Adolescent	271	39.4
	Adult	257	37.4
	Missing	11	1.6
Dosage	Q1	200	29.1
	Q2	146	21.2
	Q3	171	24.9
	Q4	171	24.9
Severity	0	385	56.0
	1	204	29.7
	2	82	11.9
	3+	17	2.5

Panel C. Interview Record and Continuous Measures

Variable	N	Mean	SD
Birth year	677	1926.2	7.9
Age at exposure	677	16.3	7.8
Interview year	686	2008.1	7.6
Incarceration days	688	1596.1	630.8
Facility count	688	1.86	0.71

Interviews/narrator	N	%
1 interview	596	86.6
2 interviews	70	10.2
3+ interviews	20	2.9
Missing	2	0.3

Panel D. Relation to the WRA Population

Measure	Value
Max |SMD|, pre-weighting	0.72
Max |SMD|, post-IPW	0.16
Max |SMD|, post-raking	0.14
Linked to registry	307 (44.6)
Valid transport weights	676 (98.3)

Panel E. Recovered Pre-Treatment Baseline Block

Variable	Category	N	%
Family SES	Small business	265	38.5
	Farming/fishing	258	37.5
	Professional white collar	60	8.7
	Wage/service	52	7.6
	Unknown	53	7.7
Prewar education	Secondary	316	45.9
	Primary or less	176	25.6
	Schooling unspecified	92	13.4
	College plus	69	10.0
	Unknown	35	5.1
English ability	Bilingual/functional	469	68.2
	Child not applicable	160	23.3
	Limited English	29	4.2
	Japanese only or none	6	0.9
	Unknown	24	3.5
Cultural orientation	Mixed Japan-U.S.	509	74.0
	U.S. embedded	163	23.7
	Japan embedded	15	2.2
	Unknown	1	0.1

Panel F. Current Narrative Outcome Profile

Dimension	N	Mean	SD
Authority stance	642	0.506	0.054
Belonging stance	642	0.394	0.082
Multimodal how	642	0.485	0.145

Category	Mean share (%)	SD	Category	Mean share (%)	SD
Guarded vigilance	12.5	18.0	Stigmatized discomposure	22.0	24.8
Diffuse unease	7.2	12.3	Oppositional citizenship	15.8	17.6
Wounded belonging	32.4	25.0	Ambivalent estrangement	10.1	12.9

Panel G. Severity Component Distribution

Component	N	%	Component	N	%
Family separation	24	3.5	Loyalty conflict	144	20.9
Parental arrest	108	15.7	Segregation	144	20.9

Notes. Panel A describes the 688 narrators in the study population. Panel B groups narrators by timing of first exposure, cumulative confinement, and betrayal severity. Panel C reports the interview record and the key continuous measures used in the analysis. Panel D shows the relation between the Densho study population and the broader WRA-confined population. Panel E reports the final merged distribution of the recovered pre-treatment baseline covariates in the treatment-observed study population. Panel F reports the mean and standard deviation of the three continuous outcome dimensions and the narrator-level six-position share profile among narrators with the final scored outcome battery ($N = 642$; 93.3 percent of the study population). Panel G reports the prevalence of the four component markers that make up the severity bundle in the treatment-observed study population. Across directly observed archive covariates, missingness never exceeds 1.6 percent. SMD = standardized mean difference. IPW = inverse-probability weighting. In the primary outcome-defined estimation sample ($N = 633$), 69 narrators (10.9 percent) retain at least one recovered `unknown` across the four categorical pretreatment covariates; the recovered complete-case subset contains 564 narrators. The upstream merged treatment/covariate frame contains 670 rows, of which 37 lack the final narrator-level outcome battery and therefore do not enter the final estimand.

The substantive reach of the study follows from the social conditions that made this archive possible. In the terms of Table 2, the Japanese American case combines high legacy inheritance with high expressive openness. That conjunction matters because it makes a wide range of later-life state–person narratives publicly legible. The same constitutional order that authorized incarceration remained in place after the camps closed, so narrators still address the authority that injured them rather than a later successor. At the same time, the postwar redress trajectory gradually made public testimony possible, so distrust, damaged belonging, and more or less composed forms of telling could enter the archive as speakable social forms rather than remain wholly private.

Seen this way, comparison is less a matter of asking whether other cases should reproduce the same distribution than of asking which conditions make similar outcomes observable. Where expressive openness is lower, as in the Great Leap Famine or post-genocide Rwanda, some narrative positions are likely to remain publicly muted: opposition may be censored, and discomposure may be difficult to distinguish from strategic silence or adherence to sanctioned memory forms (Rothschild, 2025; Jessee, 2017; Thomson, 2013). Where legacy inheritance is lower, as in post-dictatorship Argentina and Chile, survivors may still speak openly, but they address a democratic successor rather than the regime that originally inflicted the harm, so the authority relation being narrated is different (Robben, 2005; de Brito et al., 2001). What travels from this study, therefore, is not the observed distribution itself but the argument that legacy inheritance and expressive openness jointly condition which state–person narratives become speakable, observable, and publicly stabilized. The typology, treatment decomposition, and estimation strategy travel as analytic tools; the coefficients do not (Findley et al., 2021; Degtiar and Rose, 2023).

Because the archive is socially selective, the analysis is reported for two target populations. The first is the Densho narrator population itself: those who survived, agreed to be interviewed, and entered the archive. That population is substantively important in

its own right. Densho narrators are not an arbitrary convenience sample; they are participants in a public oral-history project whose very possibility depended on the postwar expressive trajectory described in Section 1. Results for this population therefore speak to how adolescent incarceration shaped the later-life narratives of people who ultimately chose to testify in public, and to whether that broader experience differed according to when confinement began, how long it lasted, and how sharply it was organized through family rupture and political coercion.

The second target population is the broader population confined in War Relocation Authority camps between 1942 and 1946. To approximate that population, the article reweights the Densho sample using the Names Registry, a comprehensive demographic listing of approximately 109,000 individuals of Japanese ancestry processed through WRA facilities (Densho, 2026b). The registry supplies birth year, sex, and prewar residence, which serve as the margins for reweighting. Of the 688 narrators in the study population, 307 (45 percent) are individually linked to registry records, and 676 (98 percent) carry valid transport weights (Table 3, Panel D). The main causal results are therefore shown in three views: first in the Densho narrator population itself, then through an inverse-probability reweighting, and finally through a raked reweighting with margins on birth cohort, sex, and prewar region (Stuart et al., 2011; Dahabreh et al., 2020). Both weighted specifications move the Densho sample substantially closer to the WRA-confined population on the observed registry margins (Table 3, Panel D). They should therefore be read as transport-oriented estimands rather than as a claim that the full confined population has been reconstructed or that selection into the archive has been eliminated.

The distinction matters because the three views do slightly different interpretive work. The unweighted results ask how adolescent incarceration shaped the later-life narratives of those who eventually testified in the Densho archive. Within that broader frame, the causal design then asks whether differences across narrators are carried by when confinement began, how long it lasted, and how sharply it was structured by family rupture

and political coercion. The two reweighted views ask how far those same relationships extend toward the broader confined population under those observed-margin transport assumptions, while also providing a check on how much the answer depends on the way the archive is brought closer to that larger population. Reporting all three keeps the historically produced Densho narrator population in view while also addressing the archive's limited representativeness (Stuart et al., 2011; Degtiar and Rose, 2023).

5 Treatment, Outcome, and Covariates

This section links the conceptual distinctions developed in the preceding sections to the empirical record described in Section 4. The aim in the body of the paper is not to catalogue every coding decision but to show how person-level treatments and narrator-level outcomes are recovered from oral-history materials recorded at the segment level. Throughout, the narrator remains the unit of causal inference. Exact coding rules, threshold values, fixed scoring settings, and implementation details for the final multimodal outcome are deferred to the Appendix.[5]

Unit of analysis. The narrator is the unit of analysis because the question is not how a particular interview segment sounds in isolation but whether exposure to state violence reorganized a person's later-life relation to public authority. Treatment is therefore defined at the person level: developmental timing, cumulative dosage, and betrayal severity are attributes of narrators, not of interviews or transcript segments. The estimand is a contrast across narrators rather than across archived documents.

Segment-level evidence nevertheless matters because it is the medium in which later-life sense-making is expressed. Each narrator may contribute multiple interviews (mean 1.17; range 1 to 6), and each interview contains multiple transcript segments. The narrator-

[5]The Appendix consolidates the coding details omitted from the body text, including treatment construction, outcome scoring, threshold and aggregation rules, auxiliary robustness reruns, and observability checks.

level outcome is therefore built from segment-level scores and shares across all eligible interviews, and population-level statements are narrator-weighted rather than interview-weighted.[6]

5.1 Treatment Dimensions

The treatment is decomposed into three person-level dimensions. Timing captures the developmental stage at first exposure. Dosage captures cumulative duration of confinement. Aggregate severity captures the qualitative coercive form internal to the confinement experience.

Timing. Timing is recovered from age at first incarceration exposure. Birth year comes from the narrator's biographical profile in DDR, supplemented where possible by cross-reference to the War Relocation Authority (WRA) Names Registry. Facility assignments are drawn from narrator testimony and biographical records. Because individually dated entry and exit records are not recoverable for most narrators, first exposure is located by matching the narrator's reported facility assignment to the historically documented operating window of that facility. The result is not an administratively exact entry date for each individual, but it is sufficient to place narrators in the developmental timing categories used in the paper.

In the main causal specification, timing enters as a binary indicator for first exposure during adolescence. Adolescence is the focal developmental contrast that motivates the timing decomposition, because the literature on political and identity formation during the impressionable years gives the strongest a priori reason to expect that first exposure during these years should leave a distinctive long-run imprint on later-life state-person

[6]This design explicitly acknowledges heterogeneity across segments and across repeated interviews. Rather than assuming that testimony is mechanically constant, the paper treats that variation as part of later-life narrative expression and aggregates across all eligible scored material at the narrator level. Appendix checks compare this all-interviews construction against simpler interview-level alternatives. Oral-history scholarship likewise treats retrospective testimony as composed across situations and over time rather than as a mechanically stable interior state (Portelli, 1991; Thomson, 1994; Summerfield, 2004).

narration (Krosnick and Alwin, 1989; Flanagan, 2013; Pfeifer and Berkman, 2018). The main causal tables in Section 7 then evaluate whether that broad timing contrast remains consequential once dosage and severity are modeled jointly. Table 3 reports childhood, adolescence, and adult groupings for descriptive presentation.

Dosage. Dosage is measured as cumulative days spent in confinement across all facilities. In substantive terms, this is the paper's duration dimension. Individual confinement spells are reconstructed from facility-level operating windows, and cumulative days incarcerated is the sum of those spells within each narrator's carceral history. The resulting distribution reflects the institutional structure of wartime confinement itself: most narrators passed through a short assembly-center phase before transfer to a much longer WRA camp, while a smaller subset also encountered segregation facilities. The number of distinct facilities per narrator (mean 1.86, range 1 to 5) provides a secondary indicator of cumulative exposure. Table 3 reports dosage in empirical quartiles for compact descriptive presentation, whereas the analysis retains the continuous incarceration-days measure.

Severity. Severity captures the qualitative coercive form internal to confinement, apart from its timing or duration. It is constructed from four binary indicators drawn from biographical metadata, interview descriptions, and registry records. Family separation records whether immediate family members were confined in different facilities or a parent was separately detained by the Department of Justice. Parental arrest records whether the narrator's father or male household head was taken into Department of Justice custody following Pearl Harbor. Loyalty-questionnaire conflict records whether the narrator or family members were drawn into the 1943 loyalty questionnaire or later citizenship-renunciation proceedings. Segregation records whether the narrator was ever assigned to a segregation facility, principally Tule Lake after its redesignation in mid-1943.

The main severity specification is an additive index summing these four indicators.

For descriptive presentation, Table 3 groups narrators by the additive count of these four markers, which ranges from 0 to 4 and has a mean of 0.61 in the analytic sample. The main causal tables instead use a normalized summary score built from the same four markers, so that the reported aggregate-severity coefficient captures movement across the full bundle of coercive injury rather than any single component on its own. That is the aggregate-severity row reported under the unweighted, inverse-probability, and raked specifications in Section 7. The paper then returns to the same four markers in a separate decomposition to ask which forms of confinement coercion, especially family separation, parental arrest, loyalty conflict, and segregation, drive that broader severity pattern most clearly.

5.2 Outcome Architecture

The outcome framework developed in Section 2 distinguishes two analytically independent dimensions of later-life narrative: what kind of settlement with the state is being narrated, and how securely or precariously that settlement can be told. This distinction enters the analysis through two outcome tracks. Track 1 aggregates segment-level classifications into narrator-level shares across the six what-by-how cells and asks whether treatment reallocates narrative mass across recognizable narrative positions. Track 2 retains narrator-level means of authority-stance, belonging-stance, and the multimodal how score and asks whether treatment shifts narrators along the underlying dimensions themselves. Taken together, the two tracks capture both movement across narrative positions and movement within them.

Scoring. Each transcript segment is first scored by a large language model (GPT-5.4; OpenAI), which returns continuous authority-stance, belonging-stance, and a text-side composure subscore. The how dimension is not measured from text alone. Let c_s^{text} denote the text-side score for segment s, and let c_s^{audio} and c_s^{video} denote the calibrated audio and

video scores on a common $[0, 1]$ scale. The segment-level multimodal how score is defined as

$$c_s^{mm} = \max\{c_s^{text}, c_s^{audio}, c_s^{video}\}.$$

A segment is classified as discomposed when $c_s^{mm} \geq 0.50$. This rule keeps discomposure from being collapsed into what a transcript reader can recover from words alone.

What classification. The two continuous what-axis scores define a two-dimensional space in which the three substantive positions occupy distinct regions. Boundary cuts partition that space into six regions, which are then collapsed into the three classes corresponding to the theoretical typology. In the canonical chi-1-corrected scored narrator corpus used in the paper ($N = 642$), the resulting distribution is 36.8 percent injury, 50.6 percent rupture, and 12.6 percent distrust.

How classification. The how dimension remains analytically independent of substantive content. A narrator may describe deep authority injury in a relatively composed way or articulate political distrust through visible strain; the point of the how measure is to preserve that variation. For the first outcome track, the continuous multimodal how score is reduced to a binary composed/discomposed distinction using fixed thresholds so that each segment can enter one of the six what-by-how cells. For the parallel outcome track, the continuous multimodal score is retained. The binary rule therefore exists only to build the narrator-level what-by-how share vector, whereas the continuous multimodal score remains available when the analysis turns to movement along the latent outcome dimensions. The archived text-side composure score is retained only as an intermediate provenance field in the scoring pipeline; it is not itself a final outcome reported in the paper. Sensitivity checks revisit the threshold choice without altering that main-text measurement logic.

A final measurement caution concerns observability on the how dimension. The mul-

timodal how score can be constructed only for narrators who were interviewed and who left enough archiveable segment material to score. If survivors whose injury remained most deeply discomposed were also less likely to be interviewed, to complete long-form oral histories, or to leave archive-ready transcripts, then selection may truncate the upper tail of narrative disorganization. The paper's how estimates should therefore be read more cautiously than the what estimates and as applying most directly to the observed archiveable narrator population.

Aggregation. Segment-level scores are aggregated to the narrator level in two ways, yielding the two outcome tracks carried into the main causal results. The first track preserves within-narrator heterogeneity as a distribution across the six cells of the what-by-how typology. For each narrator, the three what positions are crossed with the binary composed/discomposed distinction, and the outcome is the share of scored segments falling into each cell across all eligible interviews. In the main text, this compositional track is reported as six narrator-level shares corresponding to the six narrator-facing categories named above: guarded vigilance, diffuse unease, wounded belonging, stigmatized discomposure, oppositional citizenship, and ambivalent estrangement. A geometry-respecting isometric log-ratio representation of the same six-cell composition is estimated separately (Aitchison, 1982; Egozcue et al., 2003).

The second track retains the underlying continuous dimensions. For each narrator, the mean authority-stance, the mean belonging-stance, and the mean multimodal how score are computed across scored segments. This specification preserves information that any categorical classification must discard, because a narrator may shift in authority-stance, belonging-stance, or multimodal how without moving into a different what-by-how cell.

The two tracks therefore answer related but distinct questions. The compositional track asks whether treatment reallocates narrative mass across the six what-by-how categories. The continuous track asks whether treatment moves narrators along the underly-

ing dimensions themselves, including movements that remain within the same categorical region. Both are carried into the estimation framework described in Section 6, where every main causal table reports the same nine outcome columns: the six narrator-level shares from the compositional track and the three continuous narrator-level mean scores from the parallel track.

5.3 Covariates

The adjustment set follows the same logic of moving from the archive's surface record to the more complete pre-treatment background against which later-life narrative outcomes should be compared. The adjustment set combines two kinds of variables. One is a recovered pretreatment background block meant to absorb the main social processes that jointly shape wartime treatment and later-life narration. The other is a smaller narrative-production-context block observed at interview and included to absorb heterogeneity in how later-life testimony is recorded and scored. Figure 1 summarizes that ordering. Concretely, the archive-observed block includes birth year, generational cohort (Issei, Nisei, Kibei, Sansei), gender, prewar region (West Coast, inland, or Hawaii), interview year, and age at interview. The recovered pre-treatment baseline block is constructed from prewar biographical and transcript evidence and merged at the narrator level. That recovered block includes family socioeconomic position, prewar education, prewar English ability, and prewar cultural orientation, understood not as inferred psychology but as a coarse factual position with respect to Japan-linked and U.S.-embedded social worlds. The purpose of this expanded adjustment set is to strengthen the plausibility of conditional unconfoundedness while also reducing residual variation in the outcome.

The core archive covariates serve as standard pretreatment controls for baseline social composition and narrative-production context. Together, birth year, generational cohort, gender, prewar region, interview year, and age at interview absorb broad demographic, regional, cohort, and interview-timing differences that could shape both exposure and

later testimony.

The recovered pre-treatment block extends that baseline set along dimensions the archive demographics capture only weakly, especially prewar household resources, schooling, English-language access, and Japan- versus U.S.-linked social positioning. Auxiliary factual indicators, including birth in Japan, time spent in Japan, Kibei status, and Japanese language school attendance, are retained as auditable supports for that block. Wartime experiences, postwar adjustment, and later-life political reflection are excluded from baseline coding. We first recover these covariates from prewar biographical information already attached to the archive record and then use transcript evidence to fill remaining gaps when narrators describe prewar family background, schooling, language use, or social orientation directly. Table 3 summarizes both the directly observed archive covariates and the recovered baseline block in compact form; exact normalization rules, admissibility rules, recovery procedures, and missing-data conventions are deferred from the body text.

6 Causal Estimation Strategy

The paper reports the same treatment contrasts for three target populations: the observed Densho narrator sample, an inverse-probability transported WRA-confined population, and a raked WRA-confined population. In every case the estimation sample is the same 633 narrators for whom treatment histories and final narrator level outcomes can be observed. A recovered complete-case rerun of 564 narrators appears later as a robustness check rather than as the main analytic base.

To estimate these contrasts, I use a partially linear double/debiased machine-learning estimator (Robinson, 1988; Chernozhukov et al., 2018). The purpose is practical rather than methodological. Later-life narration is shaped by a rich pretreatment background, and the substantive argument should not depend on a single hand-specified functional

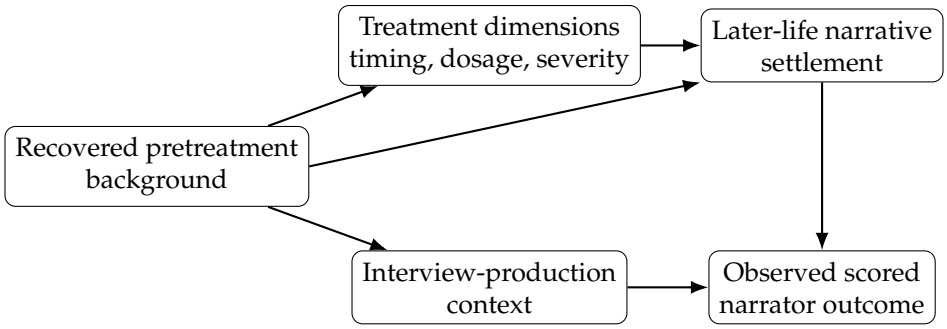

Figure 1: Stylized causal ordering of background, treatment, latent settlement, and observation. Treatment reaches the observed scored narrator outcome through later-life narrative settlement, whereas interview-production context enters only at the observation and scoring stage.

form for that background. The estimator also offers a useful inferential property: because the score is orthogonal to first-stage estimation error, moderate regularization error in the nuisance stage does not dominate the final coefficient estimate. Under standard regularity conditions, the resulting estimator is asymptotically linear and asymptotically normal, so the treatment effects can be summarized through an influence-function representation rather than by treating the first-stage adjustments as fixed parametric regressions.

In constructing the analytic sample, I avoid adding further assumptions by retaining final "unknown" baseline states as explicit categories. Narrators whose final outcomes cannot be recovered are not imputed.

Figure 1 summarizes the causal ordering assumed by the design. A recovered pretreatment background block shapes both the treatment dimensions and later-life narrative settlement. Treatment then reaches the observed scored narrator outcome through that later-life settlement, while interview-production context enters at the observation stage by shaping how the settlement is recorded and scored. The adjustment strategy therefore combines background covariates meant to absorb confounding with a smaller set of production-context variables that absorb heterogeneity in observation and scoring.

6.1 Estimating Equations and Identification

Let $i = 1, \ldots, N$ index narrators in the analytic sample. For narrator i, let Y_i denote one of the narrator-level outcomes carried into estimation, let X_i denote the adjustment vector described in Section 5.3, and let $\mathbf{T}_i$ denote the treatment term or terms relevant to the contrast under study.

The core estimating equation is the partially linear system

$$Y_i = \alpha + \mathbf{T}_i^\top \theta + g(X_i) + \varepsilon_i, \qquad \mathbb{E}[\varepsilon_i \mid \mathbf{T}_i, X_i] = 0, \tag{1}$$

$$\mathbf{T}_i = m(X_i) + V_i, \qquad \mathbb{E}[V_i \mid X_i] = 0, \tag{2}$$

where θ is the treatment coefficient or vector of coefficients of interest, and $g(\cdot)$ and $m(\cdot)$ are flexible adjustment functions for the outcome and treatment sides of the model. The estimation procedure uses cross-fitting: for each fold k, the adjustment functions are estimated on all narrators not in that fold and then evaluated on the held-out observations. This yields the orthogonalized quantities

$$\tilde{Y}_i = Y_i - \hat{g}^{(-k(i))}(X_i), \qquad \tilde{\mathbf{T}}_i = \mathbf{T}_i - \hat{m}^{(-k(i))}(X_i), \tag{3}$$

where $k(i)$ is the fold containing narrator i. The final coefficient vector then comes from the residual-on-residual regression

$$\tilde{Y}_i = \alpha + \tilde{\mathbf{T}}_i^\top \theta + \eta_i, \tag{4}$$

estimated in unweighted form for the observed archive sample and in weighted form for the two transported specifications. Let ω_i denote the estimation weight, with $\omega_i = 1$ in the observed archive sample and ω_i equal to the corresponding transport weight in the

two transported designs. The coefficient estimator can then be written as

$$\hat{\theta} = \left(\sum_{i=1}^{N} \omega_i \tilde{\mathbf{T}}_i \tilde{\mathbf{T}}_i^\top \right)^{-1} \left(\sum_{i=1}^{N} \omega_i \tilde{\mathbf{T}}_i \tilde{Y}_i \right). \tag{5}$$

Inference is based on the corresponding heteroskedasticity-robust sandwich variance estimator,

$$\widehat{\mathrm{Var}}(\hat{\theta}) = \frac{1}{N} Q_N^{-1} \widehat{\Sigma}_N Q_N^{-1}, \qquad Q_N = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} \omega_i \tilde{\mathbf{T}}_i \tilde{\mathbf{T}}_i^\top, \tag{6}$$

where $\widehat{\Sigma}_N = N^{-1} \sum_{i=1}^{N} \hat{\psi}_i \hat{\psi}_i^\top$ and $\hat{\psi}_i = \omega_i \tilde{\mathbf{T}}_i (\tilde{Y}_i - \tilde{\mathbf{T}}_i^\top \hat{\theta})$ is the sample analogue of the influence-function contribution. This is the partially linear estimator of Chernozhukov et al. (2018), implemented as a cross-fitted residual-on-residual regression in the spirit of Robinson (1988). In the transported variants, narrator-level inverse-probability or raking weights are constructed from the archival alignment variables and then carried into the estimation procedure (Stuart et al., 2011; Dahabreh et al., 2020; Deville and Särndal, 1992).

The paper's main severity specification can be written as

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta_1 A_i + \beta_2 D_i + \beta_3 S_i + g(X_i) + \varepsilon_i, \tag{7}$$

where A_i denotes timing, D_i cumulative duration, and S_i aggregate severity. To evaluate H4, the scalar severity term is replaced by four component indicators,

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta_1 A_i + \beta_2 D_i + \gamma_1 F_i + \gamma_2 P_i + \gamma_3 L_i + \gamma_4 G_i + g(X_i) + \varepsilon_i, \tag{8}$$

where F_i, P_i, L_i, and G_i denote family separation, parental arrest, loyalty conflict, and segregation, respectively. H4 is evaluated by asking whether these component coefficients are substantively non-equivalent, not by requiring all four components to operate with the same magnitude.

The causal reading of θ rests on conditional unconfoundedness, overlap, and the sta-

ble treatment value assumption (Rosenbaum and Rubin, 1983; Imbens and Rubin, 2015; Hernán and Robins, 2020). In this setting, conditional unconfoundedness means that, after conditioning on the recovered pretreatment background, residual variation in timing, duration, and severity is not systematically related to narrators' potential later-life narrative outcomes. Interview-production controls are included for a different reason: not because they determine confinement exposure *ex ante*, but because they absorb heterogeneity in how later-life narrative settlement becomes an observed scored outcome. Overlap means that the treatment contrasts of interest are observed across comparable background profiles rather than being confined to isolated strata with no empirical comparison. The stable treatment value assumption means that one narrator's confinement history does not directly alter another narrator's later-life narrative outcome, and that the coded treatment dimensions correspond to sufficiently well-defined exposure contrasts. For the two transported estimands it additionally requires that, conditional on the alignment variables used to build the weights, the treatment-outcome relationship learned in the archive generalizes to the broader WRA-confined target population (Stuart et al., 2011; Dahabreh et al., 2020; Degtiar and Rose, 2023). The estimator does not create these assumptions; it only gives the paper a way to implement them without hard-coding one parametric form for the background adjustment.

6.2 How the Two Outcome Tracks Enter Estimation

Track 1 operates on the six narrator-level shares defined by the what by how typology. For each cell $c \in \mathcal{C}$,

$$s_{ic} = \alpha_c + \mathbf{T}_i^\top \theta_c + g_c(X_i) + \varepsilon_{ic}, \qquad \sum_{c \in \mathcal{C}} s_{ic} = 1, \tag{9}$$

where s_{ic} is narrator i's share in guarded vigilance, diffuse unease, wounded belonging, stigmatized discomposure, oppositional citizenship, or ambivalent estrangement. The

main text reports the θ_c coefficients on the original share scale because they map directly onto reallocations across recognizable narrative positions. Appendix tables re-estimate the same composition in an isometric log-ratio representation to check that the substantive pattern is not an artifact of the original-scale parameterization.[7]

Track 2 retains the continuous dimensions that underlie those categories. For each dimension $j \in \{\text{authority}, \text{belonging}, \text{how}\}$,

$$z_{ij} = \alpha_j + \mathbf{T}_i^\top \beta_j + h_j(X_i) + u_{ij}, \tag{10}$$

where z_{ij} is narrator i's authority stance, belonging stance, or multimodal composure mean. These equations are estimated separately under the same partially linear design rather than as a joint multivariate system. Read together, Track 1 asks whether confinement history reallocates narrators across named narrative positions, while Track 2 asks whether the same history shifts narrators within those positions along the underlying continuous dimensions.

6.3 Cross-Fitting and Inference

The important design choice is the separation between flexible background adjustment and effect recovery. The outcome and treatment relationships with X_i are learned on one part of the sample and then evaluated on held-out observations before the final coefficients are estimated. This keeps the causal comparison from depending on a single hand-specified functional form while reducing the risk that the same observations are used both to tune the adjustment stage and to recover the treatment effect. The same logic is applied to the observed archive sample and to the two transported specifications.

Reported confidence intervals and p-values come from heteroskedasticity-robust stan-

[7] An isometric log-ratio representation maps a composition into orthogonal coordinates without treating the parts as unconstrained independent quantities (Aitchison, 1982; Egozcue et al., 2003). Appendix materials also report Benjamini-Hochberg false-discovery-rate adjustments (Benjamini and Hochberg, 1995) and additional robustness checks that are too detailed for the body text.

dard errors in the final estimating regression. The main text therefore emphasizes coefficient magnitude, confidence intervals, and raw p-values for the headline contrasts, while multiple-testing adjustments and denser robustness materials are reported separately in the appendix and table notes.

7 Treatment Effects on Narrative Stance and Composure

We begin with the joint treatment estimates reported in Tables 4–6. Across the archive sample and the two reweighted views, the same substantive pattern emerges: the broad adolescence contrast is weak, duration is at most a secondary channel, and the clearest signal is concentrated in aggregate severity. Read across both the compositional and continuous outcomes, the results do not support a simple story in which exposure during adolescence by itself dominates later-life state–person narration.

Broad binary timing does not generate a stable main effect once duration and aggregate severity are modeled jointly. Across the six what-by-how shares and the three continuous stance measures, narrators first exposed in adolescence are not consistently different from those first exposed earlier or later in ways that survive across the archive, inverse-probability, and raked specifications. On authority stance, for example, the adolescent-exposure coefficient is small and unstable across all three weighting schemes, and the same broad null pattern extends to the multimodal how score and to the ambivalent-estrangement share. Duration shows somewhat more movement than timing, especially on authority stance, where the estimated coefficient is positive and marginal in the unweighted and raked fits, but that evidence remains intermittent and does not organize the compositional outcomes with comparable consistency. Read back against H1 and H2, the joint estimates provide little support for a strong developmental-timing effect and only qualified support for dosage as an independent cumulative channel.

Aggregate severity tells a different story. Across Tables 4–6, higher aggregate severity

most consistently hardens authority stance, pulls narrative mass away from wounded belonging, and reallocates it toward ambivalent estrangement. The substantive importance of this pattern is that the estimated causal effect operates on both sides of the paper's outcome architecture. On the compositional side, aggregate severity shifts narrative mass across the what-by-how typology; on the continuous side, it raises antagonism toward public authority. The authority-stance coefficient is positive in all three specifications, and the ambivalent-estrangement coefficient is likewise positive and conventionally distinguishable from zero throughout. At the same time, aggregate severity loads negatively on wounded belonging, most clearly in the IPW fit and directionally in the other two. The long-run causal imprint of confinement therefore turns less on broad timing alone than on how coercively confinement itself was organized within that broader experience. Read back against H3, the clearest support lies here: aggregate severity is the treatment dimension that most consistently hardens authority stance and shifts narrative mass toward distrust-side outcomes.

Table 4: Main treatment effects on narrative stance and composure (unweighted DML).

	Six narrative positions						Continuous dimensions		
Treatment	Guarded vigilance	Diffuse unease	Wounded belonging	Stigmatized discomposure	Oppositional citizenship	Ambivalent estrangement	Authority stance	Belonging stance	Multimodal how
Timing D: adolescent exposure	0.058	-0.027	-0.205	0.215	-0.076	-0.047	-0.037	-0.008	0.088
	(0.120)	(0.088)	(0.238)	(0.124)	(0.129)	(0.191)	(0.083)	(0.039)	(0.106)
Dosage: total days	-8.15e-6	-4.77e-6	-1.40e-6	8.29e-6	8.18e-6	-2.75e-6	6.52e-6	4.86e-6	-4.51e-6
	(9.67e-6)	(9.02e-6)	(1.75e-5)	(1.57e-5)	(1.39e-5)	(8.30e-6)	(3.74e-6)	(4.62e-6)	(9.56e-6)
Severity: aggregate index	-0.004	-0.022	-0.095	-0.007	0.050	0.079**	0.021*	0.020	0.023
	(0.030)	(0.023)	(0.049)	(0.049)	(0.037)	(0.029)	(0.010)	(0.014)	(0.028)

Note. Each cell reports the coefficient with raw-p stars on the first line and the standard error on the second. The first six columns report the six narrator-facing positions named in the text: guarded vigilance, diffuse unease, wounded belonging, stigmatized discomposure, oppositional citizenship, and ambivalent estrangement. Stars use unadjusted p values; BH-adjusted results are reported in the Appendix. $^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$.

The weak average timing result leaves open a narrower possibility: developmental timing may matter less as a standalone main effect than as a conditioning window that changes how duration and severity are carried into later-life narration. We therefore estimate supplementary interactions between adolescent exposure and the paper's other two treatment channels, dosage and severity. This is not a fifth coequal claim along-

Table 5: Main treatment effects on narrative stance and composure (IPW DML).

	Six narrative positions						Continuous dimensions		
Treatment	Guarded vigilance	Diffuse unease	Wounded belonging	Stigmatized discomposure	Oppositional citizenship	Ambivalent estrangement	Authority stance	Belonging stance	Multimodal how
Timing D: adolescent exposure	0.496	0.400	-0.337	-0.061	-0.357	-0.091	-0.196	0.046	0.035
	(0.328)	(0.316)	(0.425)	(0.403)	(0.497)	(0.247)	(0.148)	(0.183)	(0.289)
Dosage: total days	4.46e-6	-1.45e-5	1.90e-5	-2.39e-6	1.85e-5	-1.28e-5	8.26e-6	4.93e-6	-5.57e-6
	(1.16e-5)	(1.07e-5)	(2.42e-5)	(2.14e-5)	(2.33e-5)	(1.10e-5)	(5.13e-6)	(5.91e-6)	(1.24e-5)
Severity: aggregate index	-0.044	-0.013	-0.154*	0.042	0.030	0.139**	0.041**	-0.000	0.043
	(0.032)	(0.036)	(0.068)	(0.070)	(0.047)	(0.044)	(0.013)	(0.018)	(0.038)

Note. Same column contract as Table 4. Inverse-probability weights are applied at the narrator level. Stars use unadjusted p values; BH-adjusted results are reported in the Appendix. $^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table 6: Main treatment effects on narrative stance and composure (raked DML).

	Six narrative positions						Continuous dimensions		
Treatment	Guarded vigilance	Diffuse unease	Wounded belonging	Stigmatized discomposure	Oppositional citizenship	Ambivalent estrangement	Authority stance	Belonging stance	Multimodal how
Timing D: adolescent exposure	0.310	0.347	-0.305	0.039	-0.233	-0.069	-0.125	0.091	0.239
	(0.313)	(0.361)	(0.360)	(0.337)	(0.358)	(0.199)	(0.138)	(0.163)	(0.274)
Dosage: total days	1.60e-6	-4.30e-6	1.15e-5	-8.29e-6	2.77e-5	-1.11e-5	9.13e-6	1.80e-7	-1.19e-5
	(1.25e-5)	(9.33e-6)	(2.51e-5)	(2.31e-5)	(2.49e-5)	(1.11e-5)	(5.00e-6)	(6.33e-6)	(1.24e-5)
Severity: aggregate index	-0.039	-0.033	-0.129	0.076	0.015	0.129***	0.038**	0.032	0.055
	(0.034)	(0.034)	(0.068)	(0.073)	(0.047)	(0.039)	(0.014)	(0.019)	(0.039)

Note. Same column contract as Table 4. Raking targets the marginal distributions of the pretreatment covariate set. Stars use unadjusted p values; BH-adjusted results are reported in the Appendix. $^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$.

side H1–H4; it is a boundary test asking whether the weak main timing result masks a more specific conditional timing pattern. Table 7 reports these estimates.[8] The clearest repeated pattern appears on authority stance, where the adolescent-by-dosage coefficient is negative across the unweighted, inverse-probability, and raked fits. By contrast, the adolescent-by-severity terms are weak, and the other displayed continuous outcomes do not show a comparably repeated interaction structure. This boundary check does not convert timing into the paper's main story; at most, it suggests a narrower conditional timing pattern concentrated on authority stance.

That boundary check does not displace the paper's main treatment ranking. The next question is instead whether the severity effect itself reflects a generic increase in coercion or is carried more specifically by particular forms of coercion. Methodologically, Tables 8 through 10 are not a descriptive unpacking of the aggregate-severity index but a jointly

[8]Table 7 reports only the Track 2 continuous outcomes. The full cross-track interaction inventory, including the compositional outcomes, is reported in the Appendix.

Table 7: Developmental-amplification interactions for the displayed continuous outcomes

Outcome	Interaction term	Unweighted	IPW	Rake
		-1.42e-5*	-1.70e-5*	-1.68e-5*
Authority stance	Adolescent × dosage	(6.36e-6)	(7.13e-6)	(6.67e-6)
		0.004	0.019	0.002
Authority stance	Adolescent × severity	(0.021)	(0.023)	(0.022)
		-6.56e-6	-2.11e-6	6.04e-6
Belonging stance	Adolescent × dosage	(8.58e-6)	(1.01e-5)	(9.77e-6)
		-0.008	0.039	-0.026
Belonging stance	Adolescent × severity	(0.027)	(0.032)	(0.030)
		-2.57e-5	-4.54e-6	-5.20e-6
Multimodal how	Adolescent × dosage	(1.82e-5)	(2.08e-5)	(1.98e-5)
		0.044	-0.001	-0.001
Multimodal how	Adolescent × severity	(0.056)	(0.065)	(0.062)

Note. Each cell reports the coefficient with raw-p stars on the first line and the standard error on the second. The full cross-track interaction inventory is reported in the online appendix. $^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$.

adjusted component-level rerun of the same partially linear DML design introduced in Section 6. In that rerun, the scalar treatment in (1)–(2) is replaced by the vector of the four severity components: family separation, parental arrest, loyalty conflict, and segregation assignment. Age at first exposure and cumulative days incarcerated remain in the control set, so that each component coefficient is read holding developmental timing and cumulative duration fixed. The orthogonal score and the cross-fitted estimator therefore generalize componentwise, with each component estimated after partialling out the remaining components alongside those controls in the treatment nuisance step.

The decomposition results show that the aggregate-severity effect is not a black box. The clearest component-level causal signal is loyalty conflict. Across weighting schemes, it is the only component that repeatedly shifts narrators toward distrust-side positions while also hardening authority-stance. In substantive terms, the aggregate-severity effect is carried above all by the channel that most directly encodes accusation, coerced political sorting, and betrayal-like injury within the state–person relationship.

The remaining components matter more selectively. Parental arrest is narrower and

concentrated on rupture-side outcomes rather than on the full cross-track pattern. Segregation generates a more uneven set of effects, with movement in some specifications on guarded vigilance, ambivalent estrangement, belonging-stance, and the multimodal how score, but without the same cross-specification consistency seen for loyalty conflict. Family separation produces some distrust-side movement in the compositional outcomes, but it does not anchor the broader severity story. The decomposition tables show that severity matters not because all four markers exert equal causal force, but because some forms of coercion reorganize later state– person narration more sharply than others. Read back against H4, the component results imply that the severity bundle is not homogeneous; loyalty conflict emerges as the most stable channel within it.

Table 8: Severity-component effects on narrative stance and composure (unweighted DML).

	Six narrative positions						Continuous dimensions		
Severity component	Guarded vigilance	Diffuse unease	Wounded belonging	Stigmatized discomposure	Oppositional citizenship	Ambivalent estrangement	Authority stance	Belonging stance	Multimodal how
	0.023	-0.016	0.041	-0.043	-0.027	0.062	0.001	-0.011	-0.020
Family separation	(0.045)	(0.020)	(0.044)	(0.050)	(0.032)	(0.033)	(0.014)	(0.021)	(0.027)
	0.002	-0.001	-0.049	0.042	0.009	-0.004	0.005	0.007	0.021
Parental arrest	(0.016)	(0.012)	(0.025)	(0.024)	(0.017)	(0.014)	(0.005)	(0.006)	(0.015)
	0.015	-0.024*	-0.006	-0.065**	0.054**	0.029*	0.018***	-0.009	-0.022
Loyalty conflict	(0.015)	(0.012)	(0.023)	(0.022)	(0.019)	(0.013)	(0.005)	(0.007)	(0.013)
	-0.025	0.009	-0.039	0.030	-0.009	0.021	-0.001	0.018*	0.028*
Segregation	(0.017)	(0.013)	(0.027)	(0.024)	(0.018)	(0.014)	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.014)

Note. Component rows come from the jointly adjusted decomposition model, which also controls for age at first exposure and total days of confinement. Fuller decomposition tables are reported in the Appendix. The outcome columns follow the same six narrator-facing positions and three continuous dimensions shown in Table 4. Stars use unadjusted p values; BH-adjusted results are reported in the Appendix. $^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Across the main treatment, decomposition, and interaction tables move the paper away from a simple claim about adolescence alone. What matters most is not merely that confinement began during a formative period, but that within that broader experience some coercive forms reorganized survivors' later relation to authority more sharply than others. The results therefore speak most directly to the paper's arguments about severity and about the non-interchangeability of its component parts. They speak more cautiously to duration and only weakly to a broad timing contrast. In that sense, the con-

Table 9: Severity-component effects on narrative stance and composure (IPW DML).

	Six narrative positions						Continuous dimensions		
Severity component	Guarded vigilance	Diffuse unease	Wounded belonging	Stigmatized discomposure	Oppositional citizenship	Ambivalent estrangement	Authority stance	Belonging stance	Multimodal how
	-0.023	0.022	0.020	0.044	-0.112*	0.063	-0.000	-0.006	0.025
Family separation	(0.034)	(0.032)	(0.040)	(0.060)	(0.045)	(0.037)	(0.012)	(0.024)	(0.029)
	0.012	-0.001	-0.066	0.032	0.038	0.002	0.009	0.001	0.012
Parental arrest	(0.022)	(0.013)	(0.034)	(0.033)	(0.029)	(0.019)	(0.008)	(0.009)	(0.023)
	0.021	-0.002	-0.071*	-0.050	0.042	0.053**	0.017**	-0.028**	-0.008
Loyalty conflict	(0.018)	(0.014)	(0.032)	(0.027)	(0.023)	(0.018)	(0.006)	(0.010)	(0.016)
	-0.039*	-0.009	-0.019	0.044	-0.022	0.039*	0.008	0.020*	0.025
Segregation	(0.016)	(0.017)	(0.034)	(0.032)	(0.020)	(0.017)	(0.006)	(0.008)	(0.019)

Note. Same column contract as Table 8. Inverse-probability weights are applied at the narrator level. Stars use unadjusted p values; BH-adjusted results are reported in the Appendix. $^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$.

Table 10: Severity-component effects on narrative stance and composure (raked DML).

	Six narrative positions						Continuous dimensions		
Severity component	Guarded vigilance	Diffuse unease	Wounded belonging	Stigmatized discomposure	Oppositional citizenship	Ambivalent estrangement	Authority stance	Belonging stance	Multimodal how
	-0.034	-0.032	0.028	0.094	-0.098*	0.071*	0.005	0.008	0.027
Family separation	(0.040)	(0.036)	(0.041)	(0.069)	(0.039)	(0.034)	(0.014)	(0.026)	(0.027)
	-0.003	-0.004	-0.060	0.058	0.026	-0.001	0.011	0.013	0.018
Parental arrest	(0.021)	(0.016)	(0.035)	(0.034)	(0.028)	(0.019)	(0.007)	(0.010)	(0.022)
	0.023	0.000	-0.058	-0.049	0.035	0.057**	0.016**	-0.023*	0.003
Loyalty conflict	(0.017)	(0.015)	(0.030)	(0.028)	(0.020)	(0.018)	(0.006)	(0.009)	(0.017)
	-0.038*	-0.012	0.007	0.032	-0.014	0.022	0.006	0.028**	0.016
Segregation	(0.018)	(0.016)	(0.036)	(0.034)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.006)	(0.009)	(0.019)

Note. Same column contract as Table 8. Raking targets the marginal distributions of the pretreatment covariate set. Stars use unadjusted p values; BH-adjusted results are reported in the Appendix. $^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$.

tribution is not simply to show that coercion leaves a causal trace, but to show how that trace becomes legible in later narrative form: where confinement was lived as betrayal, the afterlife of injury is more likely to take the form of distrust.

8 Robustness Checks

This section centers three checks because each bears directly on the ordering of the paper's main conclusions. The first asks whether the comparison among timing, dosage, and severity depends on one way of grouping the treatment experience. The second asks whether the strongest treatment channel, aggregate severity, still matters once the bundle is narrowed to the components least entangled with later political interpretation. The third asks whether the main severity result survives when recovered unknown states in the covariate block are dropped and the model is re-estimated on the complete-case sample. These are the checks that, if they turned out differently, would most directly reorder the substance of the paper.

Other appendix exercises remain essential, but they do different work. The appendix also asks who becomes visible in the archive, whether the sense-making pattern in how narratives are told appears in places where it should not, and how sensitive those findings are to stronger assumptions about unseen cases. These exercises mostly qualify the scope of the how findings rather than reversing the treatment ordering already visible in the main tables. For that reason, the main text concentrates on the three checks most directly tied to the paper's headline treatment claims.

Alternative treatment coding. The first main-text check belongs here because the paper's central claim is comparative: severity is more stable than timing, and dosage is more informative than a simple binary timing contrast. The question is whether that ordering survives once the treatment is written in a less compressed form. The specification reported here therefore replaces the main binary adolescent indicator with three timing

categories—childhood first exposure (before age 13), adolescent first exposure (ages 13 to 17), and adult first exposure (age 18 or older)—replaces continuous dosage with quartiles, and replaces the aggregate severity index with its component measures. If the ranking among the three treatment channels changed only because one of them had been defined more coarsely than the others, the headline conclusion would be too strong.

Table 11: Alternative timing and dosage coding on authority stance

Contrast (reference category)	Unweighted	IPW	Rake
Childhood vs. adult	-0.149	-0.444	-0.261
	(0.215)	(0.584)	(0.491)
Adolescence vs. adult	-0.121	-0.059	0.029
	(0.144)	(0.140)	(0.205)
Dosage Q2 vs. Q1	0.005	0.016*	0.013
	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.007)
Dosage Q3 vs. Q1	0.000	0.005	0.005
	(0.007)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Dosage Q4 vs. Q1	0.008	0.015	0.017*
	(0.007)	(0.008)	(0.008)

Note. Outcome is authority stance. In this alternative coding check, childhood denotes first exposure before age 13, adolescence denotes first exposure from ages 13 to 17, and adult denotes first exposure at age 18 or older; adult is the omitted timing category. The bottom dosage quartile is the omitted dosage category. Each cell reports the coefficient on the first line and the standard error on the second. For economy, the table reports only the authority-stance estimates from this specification. The appendix continues to report the corresponding compositional contrasts from the six-cell outcome typology.
$^{*}p < 0.05$.

This alternative coding check does not convert timing into the dominant explanation. On authority stance, the childhood and adolescence indicators remain imprecise relative to adulthood, while dosage becomes somewhat more visible only at the weighted margins. The appendix-side compositional contrasts point in the same direction. Adult-minus- adolescence differences remain weak, whereas childhood-minus- adolescence reaches 0.104, 0.141, and 0.158 on broader rupture and -0.087, -0.145, and -0.136 on composed narrative across the unweighted, IPW, and rake views. The right conclusion is therefore not that timing becomes a new headline finding under recoding. It is that timing, if it matters, is more developmentally differentiated than a single adolescent dummy can capture, while severity still does more of the explanatory work.

Restricted severity bundle. The second main-text check asks a narrower identification question. Because aggregate severity is the paper's strongest treatment channel, readers need to know whether that result survives once the severity bundle is reduced to family separation and parental arrest, while the timing and dosage terms remain in the model. This is the proper role of this restricted severity-bundle check. It does not isolate one purportedly cleaner severity coefficient. It asks whether the main severity pattern persists once the severity side of the treatment is reduced to family separation and parental arrest. Because this check produces estimates for more outcomes than the main text can present without repetition, Table 12 reports only authority stance and ambivalent estrangement, the two outcomes that most directly anchor the paper's main severity finding. The appendix reports the remaining outcomes.

The narrowed check preserves part, but not all, of the main pattern. On authority stance, duration remains positive across all three weighting views, but neither family separation nor parental arrest reproduces the full baseline severity result on its own. On the distrust side, family separation remains positive on ambivalent estrangement, but only the unweighted estimate is conventionally distinguishable from zero. The most defensible reading is therefore intermediate. The main severity story is not a pure artifact of one opaque component, but the full severity index carries more information than the restricted bundle by itself.

Complete-case handling. The third main-text check is about recovered missingness handling, not about the entire selection problem. The baseline design keeps recovered unknown states as explicit covariate categories so that the sample does not contract wherever archival information is incomplete. The appropriate challenge is therefore concrete: re-estimate the main specification on the complete-case sample and ask whether the headline severity result survives. That is the purpose of the complete-case check. Because the question here is whether the paper's central severity pattern survives this stricter sample

Table 12: Restricted severity-bundle check

Outcome	Treatment	Unweighted	IPW	Rake
Authority stance	Age at first exposure	0.006 (0.010)	0.003 (0.010)	-0.001 (0.006)
Authority stance	Total days incarcerated	9.71e-6** (3.67e-6)	1.43e-5** (5.36e-6)	1.42e-5** (5.30e-6)
Authority stance	Family separation	0.001 (0.014)	-0.002 (0.012)	0.003 (0.014)
Authority stance	Parental arrest	0.006 (0.005)	0.009 (0.008)	0.011 (0.008)
Ambivalent estrangement	Age at first exposure	-0.003 (0.020)	0.011 (0.027)	-0.017 (0.032)
Ambivalent estrangement	Total days incarcerated	8.71e-6 (7.45e-6)	7.61e-6 (9.03e-6)	6.71e-6 (9.74e-6)
Ambivalent estrangement	Family separation	0.066* (0.033)	0.057 (0.038)	0.065 (0.035)
Ambivalent estrangement	Parental arrest	-0.002 (0.015)	-0.001 (0.021)	0.000 (0.019)

Note. Each cell reports the coefficient on the first line and the standard error on the second. This rerun keeps timing and dosage in the model while restricting the severity side to family separation and parental arrest. For economy, the main text reports only authority stance and ambivalent estrangement; the appendix reports the remaining outcomes. $^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$.

restriction, Table 13 again reports only authority stance and ambivalent estrangement. The appendix reports the fuller set of complete-case estimates.

Table 13: Complete-case check

Outcome: severity index	Unweighted	IPW	Rake
Authority stance	0.042***	0.049***	0.048***
	(0.012)	(0.011)	(0.013)
Ambivalent estrangement	0.090**	0.103*	0.106*
	(0.034)	(0.043)	(0.042)

Note. The complete-case sample contains 564 narrators. Each cell reports the coefficient on the first line and the standard error on the second. For economy, the main text again reports only authority stance and ambivalent estrangement; the appendix reports the remaining outcomes. $^{*}p < 0.05$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{***}p < 0.001$.

The result is straightforward. The severity row remains positive on authority stance across all three weighting views and remains positive on ambivalent estrangement as well. This makes it less likely that the baseline severity result is a coding artifact created by retaining recovered unknown states as explicit categories in the main covariate block. Timing and dosage remain secondary in the complete-case rerun too, but the crucial point for the main text is narrower: the paper's headline severity result survives the stricter sample restriction.

Read together, the main-text checks narrow the strongest claims without reversing them. Treatment coding does not turn timing into the dominant story. Restricting the severity bundle preserves a weaker but still recognizable severity-side pattern. Tightening the covariate matrix to complete cases does not erase the core severity result.

9 Discussion, Implications, and Scope Limitations

The empirical results assembled in Section 7 do not support a simple developmental-window story in which adolescent exposure, considered as a binary contrast, dominates later-life state–person narration. Once timing, dosage, and aggregate severity are estimated jointly under double/debiased machine learning, the broad adolescent-exposure

indicator remains small and unstable across the unweighted, inverse-probability, and raked specifications, while cumulative duration appears as a secondary channel, with its clearest movement on authority-stance and mainly in the weighted specifications. The clearest and most consistent causal signal is carried by aggregate severity, which across all three estimands and across both the six-cell what-by-how typology and the three continuous dimensions hardens authority-stance, draws narrative mass away from *wounded belonging*, and reallocates it toward *ambivalent estrangement*. The severity decomposition shows further that this aggregate effect is not homogeneous, since loyalty conflict is the component that most consistently shifts narrators toward the distrust pole while also hardening authority-stance, whereas family separation, parental arrest, and segregation operate more selectively. Read against H1–H4, the evidence supports a treatment interpretation centered on aggregate severity, in which the form that coercion takes, particularly when it involves accusation, coerced political sorting, and institutional betrayal, reorganizes later state–person sense-making more sharply than developmental onset or sheer duration on its own. The main-text robustness checks sharpen rather than overturn that ordering: alternative treatment coding does not make timing the dominant explanation, the restricted severity-bundle rerun preserves a weaker but still recognizable severity-side pattern, and the complete-case rerun leaves the core severity result intact.

Substantively, the results extend the state-violence literature beyond the behavioral and attitudinal outcomes catalogued in recent syntheses (Barceló, 2025), since durable legacies also take the form of relational settlements between persons and the state. The what-by-how framework proves analytically productive in two respects. By separating *authority-stance* from *belonging-stance* within a two-dimensional relational space and identifying three diagonal positions within that space, it becomes possible to distinguish authority-schema injury, shame-mediated identity rupture, and explicit political distrust as substantively distinct legacies rather than as gradations of a single severity ladder. By crossing those positions with the composure axis, it also becomes visible that the same

substantive injury can be carried in different narrative forms, so that the aftermath of state violence lives both in what citizens say about the state and in whether they can say it at all. The dual-estimand comparison sharpens this point, because the unweighted Densho estimates and the two WRA-anchored transport estimates converge on the same severity-led pattern, which suggests that the central severity finding is not simply a by-product of the observable archive-entry differences captured in the transport design. At the same time, modest movement across the three views underscores that the Densho narrator population and the broader WRA-confined population are not interchangeable, so that generalisability claims must be qualified by the alignment variables through which the transport weights are constructed.

The severity-component results also speak back to the institutional-betrayal and complex-trauma literatures (Smith and Freyd, 2013; Cloitre et al., 2019). The fact that loyalty conflict carries the clearest cross-track signal supports the claim that harm inflicted through accusation and coerced sorting by a putatively protective state is not interchangeable with other forms of coercive exposure, since it reclassifies the state as a betraying authority and shifts later narrative settlements accordingly.

Methodologically, the article shows that oral-history materials can be used as causal outcome data without flattening their interpretive richness. Three pieces of that design carry forward beyond the present case. Double/debiased machine learning makes it possible to adjust flexibly for a rich pretreatment background, including a recovered prewar baseline block reconstructed from biographical and transcript evidence, without forcing the confounding adjustment into a single hand-tuned functional form (Chernozhukov et al., 2018). The multimodal how score combines text-side scoring with archived audio and video, so that narrative composure is not collapsed into what a transcript reader can recover from words alone, which matters precisely because hesitation, prosodic strain, and visible affective rupture often carry the discomposure that text-only coding misses (Portelli, 1991; Summerfield, 2004). Together these moves suggest a template for treating

archival oral history as systematic multimodal social data.

Several limitations bound the reach of these findings. The design is single-case, since the Japanese American incarceration occupies one cell of the comparative typology developed in Section 1, combining high legacy inheritance with high expressive openness. Cases that combine institutional continuity with persistent expressive closure, such as the Great Leap Famine, partial regime transition with state-managed memory, as in post-genocide Rwanda, or regime rupture with robust transitional justice, such as post-dictatorship Argentina and Chile, are likely to truncate or reorganize the observable narrative range in ways the present design cannot adjudicate (Rothschild, 2025; Jessee, 2017; Robben, 2005; de Brito et al., 2001). Coefficients should not be transported to those settings, although the analytic framework can.

The outcome data are also retrospective, which is substantively appropriate because the article asks about later-life settlement with state violence rather than immediate reaction to confinement. But the same feature also bounds the claims: narrators speak decades after wartime confinement, within a postwar context shaped by community reconstruction, redress, and the gradual public legibility of incarceration. The estimates therefore identify a later-life settlement with state violence rather than its immediate psychological aftermath. Selection into the Densho archive remains a structural feature of the data, because narrators had to survive, consent, and be drawn into the institutional networks through which public testimony became possible. The WRA-anchored transport weights narrow but do not eliminate that selection. This concern is especially important on the how dimension, where survivors whose injury remained most deeply discomposed may also have been least likely to be interviewed, to sustain long-form testimony, or to leave archive-ready multimodal materials. The main-text complete-case rerun addresses recovered missingness in the observed covariate block, but the broader archiveability problem is only partially bounded by the appendix-side checks on who enters the archive, whether similar patterns appear where they should not, and how sensitive the estimates are to

stronger assumptions about unseen cases. The how-dimension narratability concern is therefore more difficult to bound than the what-side analogue.

Three extensions follow naturally. The comparative typology invites empirical work on cases that occupy other cells of the legacy-inheritance and expressive-openness space, particularly settings in which institutional continuity is high but expressive openness is constrained, since these cases bear most directly on what the Densho archive cannot show. Longitudinal designs that track multiple interviews per narrator, where available, would make it possible to ask whether what-by-how positions are stable life-course settlements or whether they continue to move with later social and political experience. Integration of the oral-history record with WRA administrative data and adjacent archival sources would strengthen the recovered pretreatment baseline beyond what biographical and transcript evidence can supply on its own.

The framework also speaks beyond the historical case. The wartime removal and confinement of Japanese American civilians was an exercise of executive and administrative authority over a categorically defined civilian population, carried out outside ordinary criminal adjudication, and that structural form is not historically unique. Contemporary states still rely, in some settings, on administrative custody and removal regimes for civilian populations outside the ordinary penal process. These arrangements vary in legal basis, institutional setting, and stated rationale, yet they share a family resemblance insofar as executive authority can reorganize mobility, family integrity, and exposure to the state without criminal conviction. The present results suggest that the consequences of such arrangements may not be exhausted by short-run indicators of distress or compliance. If coercive confinement reorganizes how persons later narrate authority, protection, and civic membership, then episodes that subject the young to prolonged administrative custody, family disruption, or bureaucratically managed uncertainty may also generate long-lived narrative consequences that become visible only unevenly, and only imperfectly, through conventional survey instruments or short-horizon evaluations.

The broader implication of the argument developed here is not limited to the historical singularity of the Japanese American case. It is that state violence directed at the young can reorganize not only later attitudes or behaviors but the narrative terms on which authority, protection, and civic membership are understood. When civilians are confined outside ordinary criminal adjudication by executive and administrative means, the injury may persist as a durable disturbance in how the state is imagined and how one's place within the polity is claimed.

That contemporary relevance should not be read as a claim of simple equivalence across cases. The narrower claim is that non-penal confinement involving the young, family separation, and prolonged bureaucratic uncertainty can leave durable marks on the stories through which persons later narrate public authority. The framework developed here is meant to make those marks analytically visible without assuming that every later episode reproduces the same legal form, scale, or vocabulary.

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